Musical Chairs: Frequent Judge Transfers Undermine Court Productivity in India

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Abstract

We argue that a major and underappreciated cause of judicial delays is the frequent transfer of judges, which reduces productivity by leaving courtrooms vacant and prompting new judges to rehear inherited cases. In India, judge transfers are frequent partly because the rules that insulate assignments from politics generate transfers. A seniority rule converts each judge's departure into a chain of cascading reassignments. Drawing on new administrative data on 6.4 million cases from India's largest state, where judges are transferred every 7 months, we estimate that each transfer causes a courtroom to issue 8–10 fewer decisions and reduces the probability of a case being decided by 12%. Estimates based on mandatory retirements at age 60 are similar. Staggering transfers and time-bound disposal rules can attenuate these costs. We extend research on the bureaucracy to the judiciary and show how rules designed to depoliticize personnel decisions can degrade state capacity.

In many parts of the world, particularly in the Global South, court cases can take years—sometimes decades—to conclude, leading to severe court congestion. Case delays are normatively problematic and undermine the rule of law, human rights, and economic development (Voigt 2016). In this paper, we argue and show that a major cause of case delays is the frequent transfer or reassignment of judges across courtrooms. Frequent judge transfers are relatively common across the world, and their negative effects could obtain in countries as diverse as China (Zhu 2024), Japan (Ramseyer 1994), Kenya (Orina 2016; Standard Team 2015), Italy (Guerra and Tagliapietra 2017; T6 Association 2025), Nepal (Grajzl and Silwal 2020), Spain (Moral et al. 2025; Rosales-López 2008) and even the United States (O'Brien 2002; Paschal 1948).[1]

We theorize that judge transfers, which are often mandated as a way to reduce judge corruption and increase autonomy, worsen court productivity. Judge transfers are likely to cause case delays for two reasons. First, transfers increase the odds of cases being temporarily unassigned to any judge. Second, new judges feel the need to rehear portions of cases before they come to a decision. Transfers might have particularly deleterious effects in the Global South, where judges drive the disposition of cases, typically unconstrained by juries.

Why are judges transferred so often? A substantial literature ties frequent bureaucratic transfers to politicization: politicians reshuffle officials to reward, punish, and control them (Agnihotri et al. 2026; Brierley 2020; Iyer and Mani 2012; Wade 1982). We document the opposite. Judge assignments in India are deliberately insulated from politics, and although politicization might exist, we find little *systematic* affirmative evidence for it. Instead, transfers are produced by the insulating rules and norms themselves. Judge rotation rules require the regular reassignment of judges, and a seniority norm that fills each vacancy with the next-most-senior judge converts every departure into a chain of cascading reassignments—a "vacancy chain" (Chase 1991; White 1970)—that multiplies turnover. Because these rules remove discretion over assignments, no actor weighs

[1] For example, judges in North Carolina's superior courts are rotated once every six months, as mandated in the state constitution. In 1914, the Chief Justice of the state argued that the "system of rotation judges is utterly indefensible. It is antiquated, expensive to the public and to the judges, and illogical in every respect. It is the chief cause of the delays and evils in our State judicial system" (Paschal 1948, 181).

the productivity cost of an additional move. Rules adopted to protect the judiciary from politics therefore mechanically generate the turnover that undermines its productivity.

We investigate these issues in the context of India's "subordinate" or lower judiciary, which are the courts of first instance for 1.4 billion people.[2] India is a particularly useful case to study because its judicial system, modeled on Britain's and based in common law, is akin to many systems across the developing world. Alarmingly, India's lower judiciary suffers from an increasing backlog of over 40 million cases, over 40% of which have been pending for more than 3 years. This is even though Indians file among the *fewest* cases per person per year, considerably fewer than people in the United States, United Kingdom, Korea, Japan, and Malaysia (Galanter 2009). What accounts for these patterns, and what can be done to increase access to justice?

To test our theory, we leverage new "big data" on India's judges and millions of court cases, along with research designs that enable causal inference. Judges in India are transferred far more frequently than formal rules require—once every seven months in Uttar Pradesh, India's most populous state and the focus of much of our analysis. As we show, this is in part because the judiciary follows a seniority norm, intended to depoliticize the assignment of judges to courtrooms. The high frequency of transfers makes India a particularly useful case to study their consequences. We estimate that the average judge transfer out of a court causes the court to issue 8–10 fewer decisions—the equivalent of 0.2–0.3 months of lost productivity—in the three months after the transfer. This estimate is stable across three specifications that trade off precision against identification, including one that isolates transfers prompted by mandatory retirements at age 60, which are predetermined. Consistent with our theory, this result obtains because transfers cause courts to be vacant or without judges for some time, and because new judges frequently rehear portions of cases that they inherit.

Our theory and data also allow us to speak to how the negative effects of transfers can be attenuated. We show that mass or batch transfers of judges are particularly disruptive to judicial

[2] These courts also hear some appeals. Whereas most of the literature on courts in the developing world focuses on upper-level constitutional courts, we focus on lower-level courts which are citizens' first and main point of contact with the judiciary.

decision-making, even as bail cases—which have to be resolved quickly—are less likely to be slowed by transfers. These results suggest that distributing transfers over time and rules for the time-bound disposal of cases could reduce the disruptive effects of transfers.

We contribute to three broad literatures in the social sciences. The first is on the political economy of the bureaucracy in the global South. The literature on state capacity, which examines the conditions under which states invest in the bureaucracy, largely focuses on the effects of exogenous factors such as wars (Dincecco et al. 2022; Tilly 1990) and geography (Herbst 2000) on state-making. Newer works examine the effects of more endogenous factors such as the extension of the franchise (Suryanarayan and White 2021), bureaucratic embeddedness (Bhavnani and Lee 2018; Xu et al. 2023), identity and affirmative action (Bhavnani and Lee 2021; Ding et al. 2021), and politician-bureaucrat interactions (Bhavnani et al. 2026; Purohit 2024) on bureaucratic performance. We further this literature by examining the political economy of *judge* transfers, thereby extending the study of the bureaucracy to an understudied arm of the state: the judiciary. Whereas this literature explains frequent transfers as instruments of political control, we show that depoliticization can produce the same pathology. Rules adopted to insulate assignments from politics mechanically generate turnover, and this churn degrades the state's capacity to deliver justice.

The second, which straddles the social sciences, examines court efficiency and largely focuses on developed countries. This literature typically examines the effects of straightforward factors such as the number of courtrooms, judges, incentives, technology, and case complexity on judicial decision-making (Ramseyer 2012; Voigt 2016). We take this literature in a new direction by studying a developing country and arguing that seemingly innocuous and well-intentioned judge staffing decisions can shape judge productivity.[3]

As we show below, a major contribution of this project is to bring the two literatures above—on bureaucracy and judicial efficiency—into conversation with one another. In doing so, we can

[3] In related work in economics, Grajzl and Silwal (2020) study the effect of "multi-court" judging in Nepal. Other works that also examine how extraneous factors such as lunchtime and temperatures affect decisions include Chen et al. (2016); Danziger et al. (2011); Heyes and Saberian (2019).

examine the effects of the judicial bureaucracy on decision-making in India.

A third, smaller literature that this project deepens is the political science and economics work on the Indian judicial system (see Muralidharan 2024 for a recent synthesis). These works have largely focused on the developmental effects of judicial delays (Chemin 2009, 2012; Rao 2025), arguing that these undermine relational contracting and access to credit. A smaller strand has focused on the important issue of judicial bias (Ash et al. 2025; Jassal 2024) and the effects of religiosity and religious riots (Bharti and Roy 2023; Mehmood et al. 2023), temperature (Craigie et al. 2023), the media (Vasishth 2022), and legal aid (Bharti and Lehne 2024) on judicial decision-making. Papers have also focused on the question of judicial independence (see Aney et al. 2021 and Goto 2026), and little work focuses on the determinants of judicial efficiency. The latter is a pressing concern, as the country's lower judiciary has an extraordinarily high pendency despite having few case filings relative to the population.

1 Theoretical Framework

To theorize about the consequences of frequent judicial transfers, we start by defining judge transfers as any staffing decision that results in changes in the assignment of judges to courtrooms. Transfers could occur due to the movement of judges across districts, their promotion, deputation, retirement, or for other reasons. In most contexts, senior judges, bureaucrats and/or politicians are responsible for judge transfers (Malleson and Russell 2006).

The assignments of judges to courtrooms are usually subject to formal and informal rules, designed to insulate judges from political pressure while ensuring the efficient and equitable development and allocation of talent across space and time. Many bureaucracies follow two dictates in this regard. The first is that individuals, in this case judges, cannot be assigned to the regions they are from, to prevent nepotism. The second is that judges are periodically transferred—frequently in a rule-based manner—to reduce judge corruption, increase judicial independence, develop their skills, and to meet administrative needs. Indeed, these are the standard rationales for transfers outlined in bureaucratic manuals and studies of public administration (Iyer and Mani 2012; Northcote and Trevelyan 1854). The legalistic adherence to rules—in this case, transfer rules—is thought to be a necessary feature of a neutral state, designed to insulate officials from local politics (Honig 2018; Mangla 2024; Scott 2020).

Transfers are typically justified on three grounds. First, they serve as an "anti-entrenchment" mechanism: by limiting a judge's tenure in any one location, the system seeks to sever potential ties between judges and local elites before they result in corruption (Iyer and Mani 2012). Second, transfers are thought to build human capital by exposing judges to diverse legal environments—from agrarian disputes in rural areas to complex litigation in urban centers—thereby cultivating "generalist" expertise. Third, the system theoretically provides High Courts with the administrative flexibility to reallocate judicial capacity to districts with higher caseloads. In this paper, we focus on studying the *costs* of transfers, and leave it to other work to document their *benefits*.

The rationale for transfers implies that transfers will be governed by rules rather than discretion. We argue that rule-bound systems of this kind can generate excess transfers, for two reasons. First, rotation mandates set a floor on transfer frequency by design. The anti-entrenchment rule requires that judges move whether or not movement is otherwise warranted. Second, and less obviously, rule-based backfilling multiplies each move. When a rule—seniority, in the system we study—designates which judge fills each vacancy, a single departure propagates through the organization, as the designated successor's own position falls vacant, and so on down the queue. Such "vacancy chains" (White 1970) are a general feature of rule-based assignment systems—the framework has been applied to the careers of the clergy, to labor and housing markets, and organizational demography (Chase 1991)—but it has received little attention in political science. We use it to explain how rules adopted to depoliticize assignments mechanically amplify bureaucratic turnover.

Crucially, the rules that generate judge turnover also disable the mechanism that might limit it. Because insulation removes discretion over who is assigned where, no decision-maker weighs the productivity cost of an additional reassignment against its benefits. The system's strength—

that assignments cannot be manipulated—is precisely what prevents it from preventing disruptive transfers. This logic yields two observable implications. Transfer frequency should rise with the strictness with which rule-based backfilling is applied, and the length of reassignment chains should increase with the number of same-rank positions the rule governs. We return to these implications below.

Having argued that insulating rules can make transfers frequent, we next theorize about their costs, considering effects at the courtroom and case levels. When judges are transferred out of a courtroom, almost all undecided cases remain in the original courtroom.[4] The courtroom may remain vacant for a while before being assigned a new judge. Transfers are more likely to cause courtroom vacancies since not all judge transfers out of or away from a courtroom, particularly ones carried out at short notice, can immediately be met with simultaneous judge transfers into that courtroom. Replacement judges might not be available or might simply take some time to report for duty. This pattern of transfers causing vacancies has been noticed in Italy (Guerra and Tagliapietra 2017). A vacant court, of course, cannot issue decisions. Transfers, therefore, reduce courtroom productivity. Cases that are unassigned to judges are less likely to be decided.

Transfers are also likely to reduce court productivity and decrease the chances a case will be decided since judges' ability to be productive will be temporarily attenuated after transfers. New judges will take time to adjust to their new caseload and staff (see also Grajzl and Silwal 2020), slowing proceedings in the new courtroom for some time after the transfer. Additionally, new judges may require portions of inherited cases to be reheard as they familiarize themselves with old matters, particularly if the written record is unclear or if judges prefer to personally examine witnesses and lawyers.

In theory, transfers could have an anticipatory effect, even before they occur. Much as term limits are thought to undermine leader incentives, judges faced with an impending transfer could face the

[4] In our data, 3.2% of cases were taken with judges when they moved to a new courtroom. Such case rather than judge transfers do not appear to slow decision-making to a significant degree. This is perhaps unsurprising since judges are only allowed to take cases with them if they are close to a decision (that is, if they have fully heard lawyers, witnesses, etc.).

temptation to leave cases for the next judge. Judges who know that they are about to be transferred will also spend time preparing for their relocation, which will undermine their productivity. On the other hand, impending transfers could also cause judges to speed up the disposal of some cases, such as those for which hearings have been completed and the court has yet to issue a decision. As we describe below, anticipation effects are likely to be limited in the Indian context because transfers are typically announced very soon (two to four weeks) before they are effectuated, and since the annual reviews that India's judges are subjected to incentivize judges to be as productive as possible.

Having theorized about the possible effects of transfers on judge decision-making, we also consider ways to attenuate these effects.

One way to reduce the negative effects of transfers would be to better stagger them throughout the year. However, for reasons of administrative convenience, bureaucracies tend to process transfers in large batches at particular times of the year. Because mass transfers are planned in advance, replacement judges can be lined up, making vacancies less likely. At the same time, the simultaneous change of many judges strains a court's shared administrative capacity—its readers, stenographers and clerks must process many handovers at once—causing cases to require additional hearings. Since the vacancy savings accrue transfer-by-transfer whereas the strain on shared staff compounds as more judges change simultaneously, we expect mass transfers to be more disruptive than staggered transfers on net. This account yields three further testable implications: while both mass and staggered transfers should slow judicial decision-making, relative to staggered transfers, mass transfers should result in fewer vacancies but more hearings.

A second way to reduce the effects of transfers is to ensure that cases are decided quickly. Indeed, most judicial systems are able to decide some cases—such as bail cases—quickly. Quick disposal rates ensure that fewer cases are "at risk" of being subjected to judge transfers since they will be decided and therefore exit the court system speedily. This reasoning is not tautological. It is not that quick disposal rates cause quick disposals. Rather, it is that a quicker process ensures that fewer cases bear the brunt of the negative effects of transfers.

Our theory implies that the negative effects of transfers will be most pronounced where two conditions hold. First, judges must set the pace of case disposal, so that reassigning a judge directly disrupts a case's trajectory. Where juries drive the litigation calendar, a change in judge may be less consequential. Second, there must be a large stock of pending cases, ensuring that many are exposed to each transfer. Where cases are resolved quickly, few cases will be affected, muting the effects of transfers. These conditions are present to varying degrees worldwide, and we return to the external validity issue later.

Having outlined our theoretical expectations about the consequences of judicial transfers for court productivity and possible ways to reduce the costs of transfers, we highlight why India is a good case to study and note some of its relevant characteristics.

2 India's Lower Judiciary: Massive Judicial Delays Despite Few Case Filings

India's legal system is based on common law and was inherited mainly from the British. In this respect, it is similar to the legal systems of more than 40 other common law countries and many more countries with mixed legal systems (Kritzer 2002), several of which also suffer from judicial delays (Dakolias 2014). The Indian judicial system is also relatively open, in that rich data on its courts are posted online. As such, studying the Indian judicial system is possible, and insights from such studies could apply to other developing countries with common law systems and judicial delays.

The Indian judiciary is made up of the upper (the Supreme Court of India and the country's 25 High Courts—these are constitutional courts) and the lower judiciary (there are over 14,000 of these courts of first instance). Case pendency is high across the judiciary and is among the worst in the world. The lower courts—the focus of our study—account for most pending cases. Despite being a federal country, India's judicial system is unitary in that it applies and interprets the country's federal and state laws to the cases before it.

India's courts are staffed by professional judges who are (with some exceptions) generalists, that is, they largely do not specialize in adjudicating specific matters (except for most but not all tax matters, which separate revenue courts handle). Therefore, judges of the same level of seniority can be transferred at will because their skills are comparable. In the lower judiciary, judges sit singly (rather than in benches with multiple judges) to decide cases. They are assisted in their work by professional staff, including "readers," stenographers and clerks.

The country's lower courts are created by state governments, and they are staffed by judges recruited directly from law schools or the State Bar Associations using meritocratic selection procedures, including exams and interviews.[5] The lower judiciary has a lot of corutroom vacancies, with approximately 25% or 5,000 judge positions vacant. Once recruited, judge promotions and transfers across and within India's administrative districts occur at the behest of "collegiums" of up to three of the senior-most judges in the state High Courts (the equivalent of US Circuit Courts), with inputs from the senior-most judges in each district. Although state and national level politicians have no de jure role in this process, a political economy approach suggests that there could be unofficial channels of influence. We return to this issue later.

Judges in India's lower courts are evaluated annually using Annual Confidential Reports. Although the precise rubric for these evaluations varies by state, all evaluation systems place great weight on the number of decisions issued (Deva Rao et al. 2018). The evaluation system has been criticized for emphasizing quantity over quality (Gupta and Bolia 2024).

Judge transfers are supposed to occur based on staffing needs, subject to rules and norms designed to ensure the even development and application of talent across space and a lack of corruption. To these ends, judges are not allowed to work in their home districts, and cross-district judge transfers are mandated every three years. In subsequent sections, we describe how transfers operate in practice, showing that there are many more transfers than mandated. We then turn to estimating the costs of judge transfers.

[5] Since 2025, judges are required to have practiced law for a minimum of three years prior to taking these exams.

3 Research Designs and Big Data

To examine the degree to which judge transfers slow decision-making, we conduct analyses at the courtroom and case levels. At the courtroom level, we draw on a panel dataset of 2,518 courtrooms observed monthly between 2015 and end-2018 to model our main outcome of interest—the number of decisions issued by a courtroom in a month-year—as a function of transfers and its leads and lags. The number of decisions issued by a courtroom is a standard measure of judicial productivity used to evaluate judges across the world, by academics and practitioners (Deva Rao et al. 2018; Ramseyer 2012; Voigt 2016).

A straightforward analysis of the courtroom-month panel dataset would estimate the following two-way fixed effects equation.

$$Y_{ct} = \alpha + \beta Transfers_{ct} + \delta_c + \gamma_t + \epsilon_{ct} \tag{1}$$

wherein the outcomes (the number of decisions, hearings, their ratio, and courtroom vacancies) for a courtroom c in month t are modeled as a function of an indicator for whether the courtroom experienced the transfer out of its judge ($Transfers_{ct}$) and courtroom (δ_c) and month-year (γ_t) fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the courtroom level. A recent literature suggests that the two-way fixed effects estimator is problematic if treatments are staggered and effects are heterogeneous across units or over time (De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille 2020; Goodman-Bacon 2021). We therefore use the dynamic difference-in-difference estimator due to De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille (2024). This estimator is robust to heterogeneous effects and is well-suited to cases such as ours, where the treatment is binary and turns on for one period at a time (in other words, it is non-absorbing).[6] It compares switchers (courtrooms where the treatment changes) and nonswitchers (courtrooms where the treatment remains the same) with the same baseline treatment, and allows for dynamic effects.

[6] Other new estimators, such as those due to Callaway and Sant'Anna (2021) and Sun and Abraham (2021) are for absorbing treatments and therefore cannot be used here.

The degree to which court productivity suffers in the wake of judge transfer likely depends on whether the court remains vacant and the kind of judge that is transferred in. We do not focus on studying the effects of incoming judge characteristics since these are post-treatment, that is, they are assigned after the transfer out of the previous judge.

For our case-level analysis, we turn to our dataset of the approximately 6.4 million cases filed in Uttar Pradesh between 2015 and 2018, and estimate the following equation using a fixed effects linear probability model.

$$Y_{ir} = \alpha + \beta Transfers_{ir} + \gamma X_{ir} + \delta_c * \zeta_r + \lambda_a + \eta_t + \epsilon_{ir} \tag{2}$$

This equation relates our outcome variables (an indicator for whether a case i in courtroom r is decided by end-2021,[7] and the number of hearings and spells for which the case was unassigned to a judge) to the number of judges transferred out of the courtroom while the case was ongoing ($Transfers_{ir}$), controlling for a vector of case-specific controls (X_{ir}), case type (δ_c)[8] and courtroom (ζ_r) fixed effects and their interactions, act (λ_a) fixed effects, and filing month-year (η_t) fixed effects. Case-specific controls are the number of sections under which cases are filed (with a missing-data indicator), indicators for bailable and nonbailable crimes, and indicators for the parties' gender (with missing-data indicators) and whether they are the government. Standard errors are clustered at the courtroom-case type level.

We code a courtroom as experiencing a judge transfer if the judge assigned to it is moved out. As we will describe later, such judge reassignments could be prompted by various factors, including the rule that judges are transferred across districts once every three years, judge promotions, and retirements. When court cases are filed, the court administration or registrar assigns them to

[7] We measure the outcome (whether a case was decided) and the treatment (the number of transfers) as of end-2021 to give cases filed later in our data sufficient time to be decided. We began scraping the eCourts platform in 2022, and since courts update their websites with a lag, end-2021 represents the latest date for which we are confident the case-level data are reliably complete.

[8] We code cases as falling into four mutually exclusive, collectively exhaustive types: civil cases, criminal cases, bail cases and unclassified cases. See Appendix A for coding rules.

courtrooms in an arbitrary manner (Ash et al. 2025; Rao 2025), where they typically stay until decided.[9] A court case is therefore coded as experiencing a judge transfer when a judge assigned to its courtroom is moved out. Since courtrooms often experience several judge transfers over time, the key independent variable for our case-level analysis is the count of all judges who were transferred out of the court while the case was ongoing.

Although our selection-on-observables strategies for the courtroom and case-level analyses control for a wide range of confounds, unobserved confounding could still theoretically bias the estimated effects of transfers. To better isolate the causal effect of judge transfers, for both the courtroom and case-level analyses, we focus on transfers due to retirements. The courts we study have a mandatory judge retirement age of 60, and judges do in fact retire the week they turn 60. This renders the assignment of these transfers plausibly exogenous to courtrooms and cases, which allows us to more credibly estimate the causal effect of transfers. As we show below, the local average treatment effects of retirements are broadly similar to the effects of other transfers.

A potential concern with this specification is that cases pending longer may mechanically accumulate more transfers while also being less likely to be decided by end-2021, generating a spurious negative association. Our design addresses this in several ways. Filing month-year fixed effects ensure that cases are compared only within the same filing cohort, equating the period over which each case could accumulate transfers. Case complexity controls—specifically, act fixed effects and the number of sections a case is filed under—absorb variation in case difficulty that could simultaneously drive longer duration and more transfers. In a further test, we re-measure both transfers and the outcome within the same one-, two- and three-year windows from filing, so that no case accumulates transfers beyond the common horizon at which all cases are compared.

We draw on two datasets from Uttar Pradesh, India's largest state with a population of over 240

[9] Cases have to be filed in the nearest court that decides the concerned case type. For example, junior division courts hear more minor matters, whereas senior division courts hear more major matters involving disputes over larger amounts or penalties. Once cases are filed in the nearest court, they are assigned to courtrooms within that court randomly, as outlined in the "Case Management through CIS" manual (e-Committee, Supreme Court of India 2018, 14).

million, for our analyses. These were created by scraping judge and case data from the country's eCourts platform (since around 2006, India's courts have been required to upload a range of data to this website), and from current and previous versions of the websites of the Allahabad (that is, Uttar Pradesh) High Court and district courts.[10] Dataset construction details are provided in Appendix A.

The first, courtroom-month panel dataset describes courtroom productivity and judge transfers across 2,518 courtrooms between January 2015 and December 2018. 2,275 judges served in these courtrooms in the period under study. In Appendix Figure B1, we graphically depict the substantial variation in treatment (that is, the transfer of a judge away from a courtroom) timing across courtrooms. A courtroom is the specific room in a court, which is in a court complex, where a single judge presides and cases are heard. Court complexes typically contain several courts, which are in turn composed of courtrooms at the same level. For instance, our dataset contains observations for courtroom number 2, at the Civil Judge Junior Division Level or court, in the Bahraich District Court Complex. These data are summarized in Appendix Table B1.

The second, case-level dataset provides details on approximately 6.4 million cases filed in Uttar Pradesh's lower judiciary between 2015 and 2018. The dataset allows us to thickly describe each case, including the courtroom(s) to which it was initially assigned and transferred to, its type (civil, criminal, bail, etc.), the acts and sections that the case was filed under, and the identities of the petitioners and respondents. The data also allow us to document whether the case was decided or pending as of end-2021. These data are summarized in Appendix Table B2.

We enrich our understanding of these big datasets through interviews with India's lower court judges, and by engaging with the limited discussions of the issue in the press and in judicial decisions.

[10] To scrape the case-level data, we relied on the listing of cases filed between 2015 and 2018 in Uttar Pradesh provided in Ash et al. (2025). Our new scrape yielded fields absent in the public release of the original dataset, including the courtrooms associated with the case, and an indicator for whether a case was decided by the end of 2021. We focus on cases filed from 2015 on, when the judge transfer data are consistently reported.

4 Rule-Bound Judge Assignments Make Transfers Frequent

In this section, we provide the first systematic documentation of judge transfers in India. To explore the causes of frequent judge transfers, we familiarized ourselves with the official documentation and secondary literature on the issue, supplemented with interviews with judges. In two empirical exercises, we also look for and fail to find systematic evidence for the politicization of judge transfers. Ironically, we find that a major cause of transfers is the judicial system's attempts to ward off the politicization of judge transfers via a seniority rule used to match judges to courtrooms. This rule results in frequent, rule-based transfers. This section thus provides evidence for the first stage of our argument: that insulating rules, rather than politics, drive the frequency of transfers. It also motivates our identification strategy, which focuses on judge transfers due to retirements.

Our data suggest that judicial transfers are frequent. Across India, judges are transferred across positions once every 11 months. Figure 1 maps the cross- and within-state district variation in judges' time in their postings. It reveals that there is substantial cross- and within-state variation in judge transfers. For example, judges in Uttar Pradesh and Andhra Pradesh spend an average of 7 months in their positions, even as judges in Chhattisgarh and Haryana are in their positions for more than double the time. Strikingly, the variation in judge tenure across districts within states is also substantial. The average judge tenure per district in the state of Uttar Pradesh, which is the focus of our analysis, ranges from 5–12 months.[11] To our knowledge, this is the first systematic documentation of the frequency of transfers of lower court judges in India and its spatial variation.

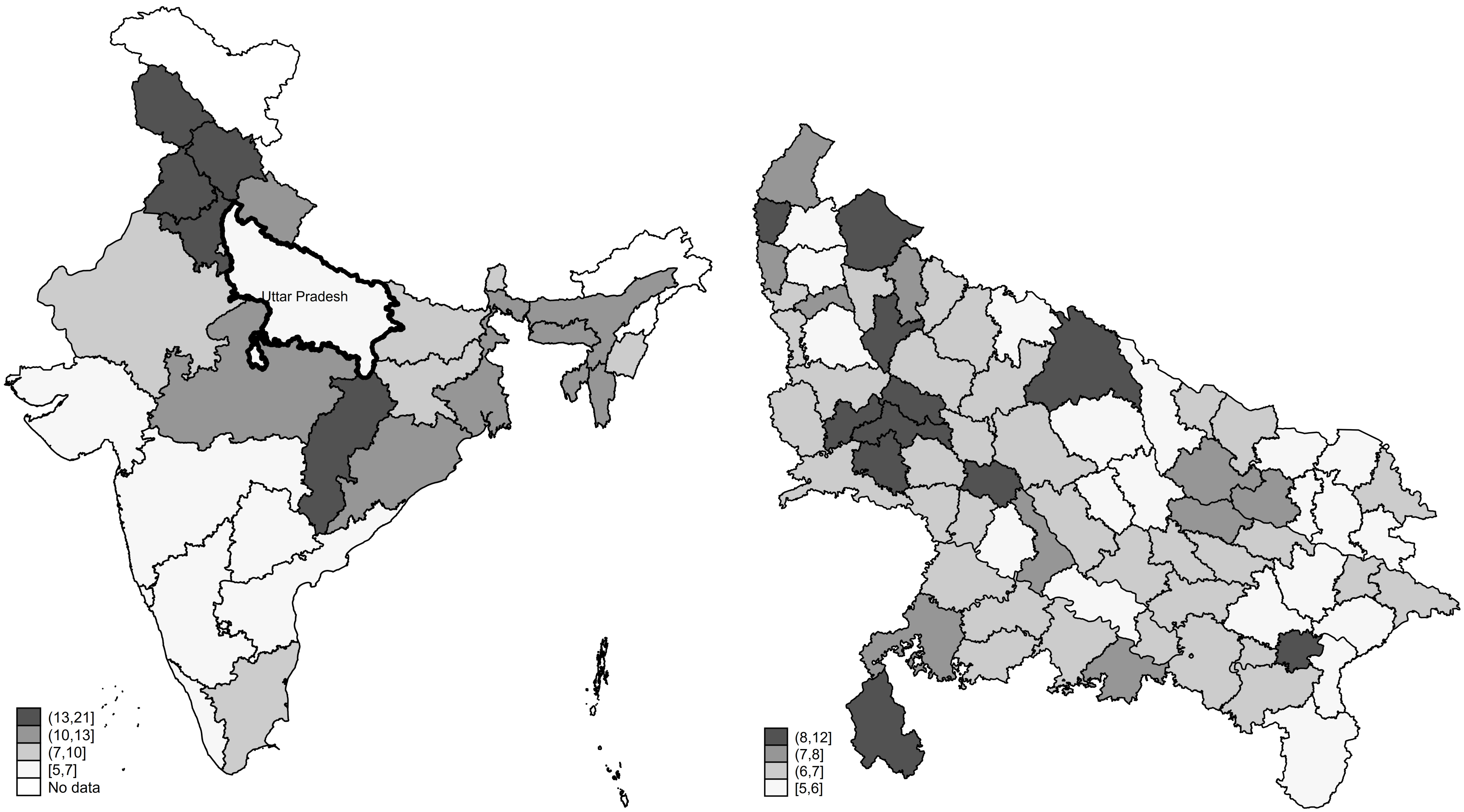
Our courtroom-month data for Uttar Pradesh also allows us to describe the *types* of judge transfers in some detail. We group transfers into mutually exclusive categories, assigning any multi-type transfer to the most consequential status change. Some category shares are observed directly; others are regression-based estimates (see Appendix A for details). In our data, 14% of transfers occur across districts. A clear set of rules mandates cross-district transfers every three

[11] The substantial cross-state variation in the frequency of judge transfers is perhaps unsurprising, as state High Courts (the Indian equivalent of circuit courts in the US) exercise significant administrative discretion over transfer policies within their states. The within-state variation is perhaps more surprising, an issue to which we return below.

Figure 1. Average months judges spend in their postings

(a) India

(b) Uttar Pradesh



Source: Own calculations, based on new judge data scraped from the eCourts website.

years (in fact, judges spend an average of two years in districts; we discuss possible reasons why this is lower than the mandated three-year term below), and when judges are transferred, they are moved to non-contiguous districts in a separate zone (the state is divided into zones by an Administrative Committee). Judges are also prohibited from serving in their home districts.

7.5% of transfers are due to judge promotions. At the five-year mark, judges are promoted from the junior to the senior division. At the ten-year mark, they are promoted from the senior division to the "district and sessions judge" level. A few judges are also promoted later in their careers from the "district and sessions judge" level to a High Court. An additional 4.2% of transfers are due to deputations, as judges serve in administrative roles, including as court registrars and to serve on statutory bodies and judicial commissions. 2.9% of transfers are due to the recruitment of new judges into courts, which causes the previous junior-most judges to be moved up a level. 1.8% of total transfers are due to retirements, which occur the week judges turn 60. As discussed, we leverage the latter rule to help identify the causal effects of transfers. Lastly, we estimate that 36.6% of transfers occur across courtrooms within districts for administrative reasons, to meet the needs of local courts and to ensure the professional development of judges.

By our calculations, approximately a third of transfers are "cascading," prompted by the recruitment date-based seniority system followed by the Uttar Pradesh judiciary. The seniority system operates as follows. When one of the "primary" judge transfers described above creates a vacancy in a courtroom, the next most senior judge (that is, the earliest-recruited judge with the same rank) in that court will be moved to the vacant courtroom. This will then create yet another vacancy, which the second next most senior judge will be moved to fill, and so forth. Take the example of the retirement of Judge Vinay Kumar on January 31, 2017, from courtroom number 2 of the District and Sessions Judge Court within the Pilibhit District Court complex. Courtroom 2 remained vacant until February 3, 2017, when a cascading series of transfers began. Courtroom 2 was assigned to Judge Pankaj Kumar Upadhyay, who was moved out of courtroom 3. Courtroom 3 was then filled by Judge Ahasan Husain, who was moved out of courtroom 4. Courtroom 4 was assigned to Judge Vijay Kumar Gupta, who was moved out of courtroom 5. Courtroom 5 was finally assigned to Judge Narendra Pal Singh Tomar as an additional charge, requiring him to manage both courtrooms 5 and 6 simultaneously.[12] Most Indian High Courts follow similar seniority-based assignment norms, although they vary in the degree to which they apply them across judge levels. Such institutional variation likely helps explain some of the cross-state differences in judge tenure previously documented in Figure 1. We leave systematic testing of this hypothesis to future work.

The seniority system magnifies the effects of transfers by prompting cascading transfers in their wake. To estimate the magnitude of this cascade, we collapse our data to the district–court type–month level and regress total transfers on contemporaneous and one-month lagged counts of recruitment, promotion, inter-district, deputation and retirement transfers, with district–court type and month-year fixed effects (regression 1 of Appendix Table A1). Depending on their type, transfers trigger between 0.38 and 1.01 cascading transfers each. Consistent with the seniority mechanism, cascades are more frequent when there are more courtrooms at any particular level in a district. In particular, the data suggest the transfer cascade rises by 0.16 reassignments per standard deviation of court size (bottom row of Appendix Table A1). The Pilibhit example above illustrates a cascade of four reassignments in a court with six courtrooms. Such long chains are atypical: the average cascade is shorter because many courts have fewer courtrooms and because cascades are sometimes truncated when judges take additional charge of a second courtroom rather than being formally reassigned. Using the regression-based cascade rates to decompose total transfers, we estimate that 33.1% of all transfers are due to cascades (Appendix Table A2). All things equal, eliminating cascades would therefore lengthen the average judge's time in position from approximately 7 to 10.5 months.

A substantial literature in the Global South (Agnihotri et al. 2026; Brierley 2020; Wade 1982) describes how bureaucrats are frequently transferred at the behest of politicians. Such politicization is less likely in our context as judge assignments are formally determined by senior High Court (the Indian equivalent of US Circuit court) judges, rather than politicians, and since the seniority

[12] Moog (1992, 24) observed the operation of this system in the 1980s, remarking that "This occurred in Varanasi District when the civil judge received a promotion to additional district judge and was transferred to another district. The first additional civil judge became a civil judge, and all the other additional civil judges moved up one position."

system substantially shapes precisely which judge is assigned to a courtroom. The latter means that while senior judges and politicians might be able to influence whether a judge is moved out of a court, they are less likely to be able to determine precisely which judge is transferred in.

That said, under conditions of "perverse accountability," rent-seeking politicians might pressure senior judges to transfer junior judges to influence them. While we suspect that the occasional judge transfer is in fact initiated at the prompting of politicians, our large-n analyses of judges described below fail to yield systematic evidence in favor of politicization. In the rest of this section, we summarize our efforts to explore the possibility that judge transfers are in fact politicized.

First, we take a decomposition of variance approach, originally developed in the economics literature to estimate the effect of teachers and managers (Bertrand and Schoar 2003; Rockoff 2004), to parse the contribution of various factors in explaining judge transfers across space and time. To implement this, we leverage the courtroom-month dataset introduced previously, and model judge transfers as a function of politician, judge, court type, and month-year fixed effects. If there is no politicization (the null hypothesis), we would expect the test of the joint significance of politician fixed effects to yield a small F-statistic and for politician fixed effects to explain negligible residual variation in judge transfers.

Our analysis—presented in Appendix Table B3—provides little evidence that transfers are meaningfully politicized. While the joint significance test of politician fixed effects rejects the null at conventional levels, the F-statistic is small (1.65) and politician fixed effects jointly explain less than 1% of the residual variation in judge transfers, suggesting that any political influence over transfers is substantively negligible. Consistent with our identification strategy, which leverages retirement transfers, these effects are much weaker for retirement transfers. The F-statistic falls to 0.64—well below conventional thresholds for rejection—and politician fixed effects explain approximately zero variation.

Second, we leverage data on judge transfers across courtrooms between 2015 and 2018 to examine whether changes in politician characteristics due to elections are associated with changes in judge transfers. In particular, we note that two subsets of politicians will be particularly likely to influence judge transfers. First, politicians from the ruling party (that is, the party with a legislative majority; this was the Samajwadi Party until March 2017 and the Bharatiya Janata Party thereafter) are likely to be able to influence judge transfers via pressuring the senior judges responsible for transfers directly, or indirectly via their influence over the executive. Second, politicians charged with crimes might be particularly keen on transferring judges to obtain favorable judicial outcomes for their cronies or themselves. Politicians might seek the transfer of judges who are assigned to hear their cases, to delay decision-making and/or ensure favorable judicial outcomes (Poblete-Cazenave 2025). Alternatively, if politicians charged with crimes increase criminality more generally because of demonstration effects or because they run criminal enterprises (Prakash et al. 2026), they might seek the transfer of judges in their districts, whether they are assigned to hear their specific cases or not.

This analysis, too, fails to yield clear evidence that judge transfers are politicized along the lines theorized above. Consider first the hypothesis that ruling party politicians are better able to transfer judges. A regression discontinuity analysis using close elections between ruling party and opposition politicians yields no evidence that ruling party victories cause more transfers—a precise null that rules out increases larger than roughly a fifth of mean transfers (left-hand panel of Appendix Figure B2; estimates in Appendix Table B4).[13] A second discontinuity analysis of close elections between politicians charged with crimes and others is similarly null, with a comparable bound (middle panel). Lastly, a regression discontinuity analysis of close elections between ruling party politicians charged with crimes and others likewise yields no significant effect (last panel). In each case, the running variable varies smoothly through the threshold, with no sign of manipulation (Appendix Figure B3).

In sum, two systematic analyses of judge transfers—a decomposition of variance analysis, and examinations of the hypotheses that ruling party and criminal politicians are more likely to transfer

[13] To assign courtrooms to single-member districts or constituencies and their politicians, we use data on case origins. So if a courtroom mostly hears cases from a constituency, data on politicians from that constituency is matched to that courtroom.

judges using the regression discontinuity estimator—fail to provide systematic evidence of the politicization of judge transfers. In other words, while we are unable to rule out the possibility that the occasional judge transfer is in fact politicized, judge transfers in general do not appear to be shaped by politics. More broadly, since the productivity costs of transfers arise from vacancies and additional hearings—mechanisms that operate regardless of whether a transfer is triggered by a retirement, a cascade, or an administrative decision—we can credibly estimate these costs using all transfers. That said, due to an abundance of caution, we also separately estimate the effects of retirement transfers, which are predetermined.[14]

5 Transfers Reduce Courtroom Productivity

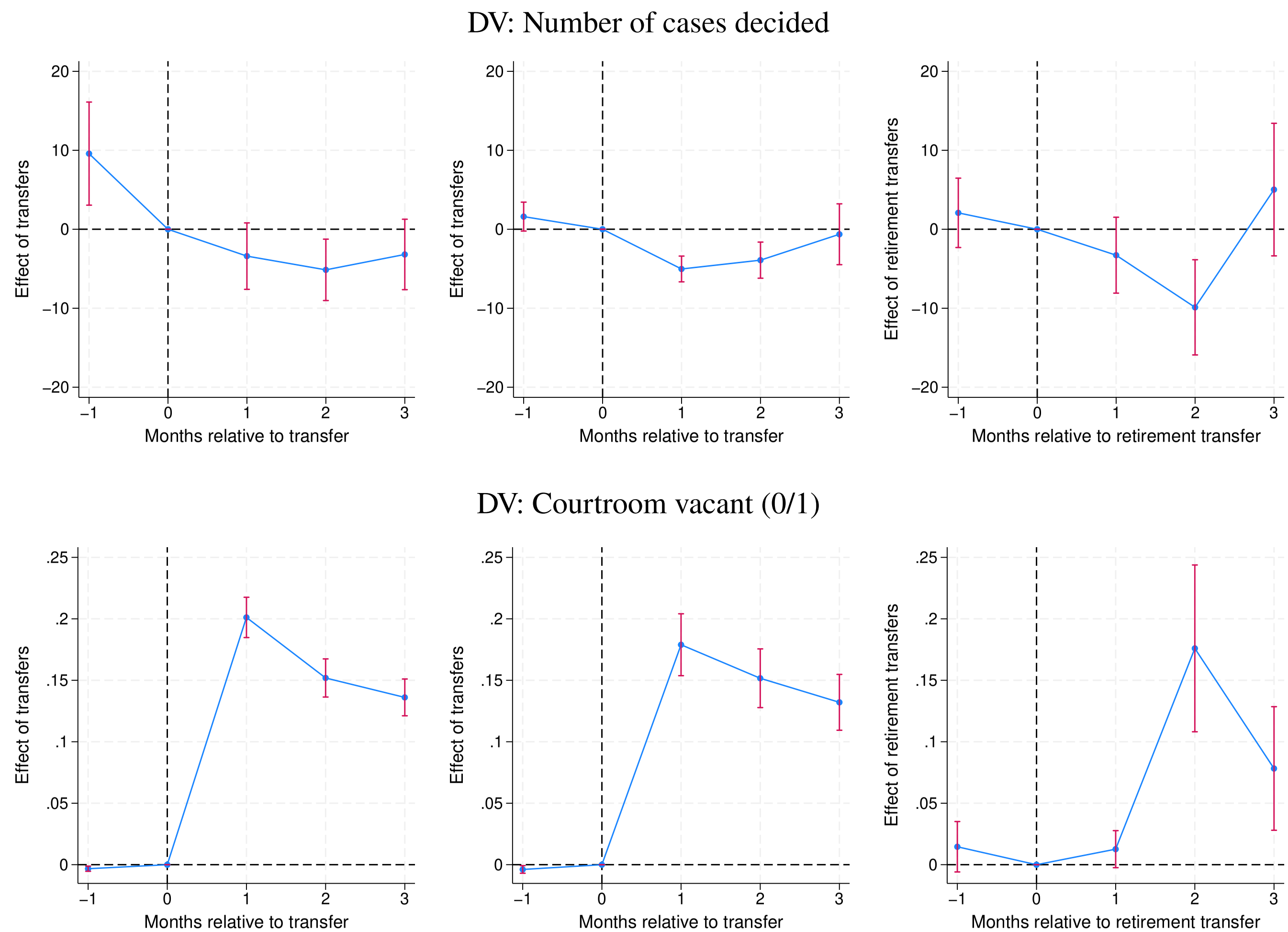
To examine the effects of transfers on courtroom productivity, we estimate equation 1 using the dynamic difference-in-difference estimator and the number of cases decided in that month-year as the outcome variable.[15] Since judges in Uttar Pradesh are transferred once every seven months on average, we estimate effects for three months after the transfer and include one pre-treatment placebo, for a total event window of five months. This ensures that the estimation window does not exhaust the average time between transfers, leaving sufficient months in which non-switching courtrooms can serve as credible comparisons. The results of our analysis are depicted in Figure 2 and are summarized in Appendix Table B5. We present three estimates that trade off precision against identification: the effects of all transfers in all courts, of all transfers in District and Sessions courts, and of retirement transfers in District and Sessions courts. As we show, all three imply that a transfer costs a courtroom approximately 0.2–0.3 months of productivity.

The top left panel of the figure shows the estimated effects of total transfers on the number

[14] A comparison of bureaucrat and judge transfers is instructive. Although India's senior bureaucrats are also transferred frequently—Iyer and Mani (2012, 75) report the average tenure of Indian Administrative Service officers is 16 months—bureaucrat transfers are arguably more politicized. Politicians, particularly government ministers, help evaluate bureaucrats and have a direct say over their reassignments. Politicians can leverage bureaucrat preferences over places—specifically, their desire to be near their home districts and urban areas—using preferred assignments as carrots and undesirable assignments as sticks to induce compliance (Agnihotri et al. 2026). Although a similar dynamic could obtain with respect to cross-district judge transfers (which constitute 14% of the total), the analyses reported above reveal no systematic evidence of such political influence.

[15] We code a case as decided in that month-year based on the date of final decision.

Figure 2. Transfers reduce the number of decisions and increase courtroom vacancies



Notes: The dependent variables are the number of cases decided (top row) and an indicator for whether the courtroom is vacant or not (bottom row). The data for the plots in the first column cover all courts; the data for the remaining plots cover district courts, from which judges retire. The independent variables are indicators of whether the courtroom experiences a transfer (the first two graphs in each row) and a retirement transfer (the last graphs in each row) and their leads and lags. See text for details.

of cases decided. It suggests that the courts issue 3–5 fewer decisions for the three months after transfers. In the second month, this effect is statistically significant. Since the average courtroom issued 44 decisions per month, this amounts to a 7–12% reduction in courtroom productivity. Cumulatively, courtrooms issued about 10 fewer decisions in the three months after a transfer.[16] Put differently, courtrooms lost 0.2 months of productivity because of transfers.

The estimated effects of transfers are significantly positive in the month prior to their occurrence. Although this is consistent with the positive anticipation effect theorized above (where judges might accelerate the disposal of cases where they have completed hearings) and the fact that transfers are typically announced two to four weeks before they are effectuated, it suggests a violation of the parallel trends assumption that is the basis of the dynamic difference-in-difference estimator. The pre-transfer surge also raises the possibility that transfers retime rather than reduce decisions, with departing judges bringing forward the disposal of nearly-complete cases. Two pieces of evidence weigh against a pure retiming account. First, the case-level analyses below show that the negative effects of transfers on the probability that a case is decided persist (Table 1). In other words, lost decisions are not recovered in subsequent months. Second, our two remaining specifications, which are less subject to anticipation and to the endogenous timing of transfers, recover effects of similar magnitude.

To address this issue and assess whether transfers do indeed *cause* a reduction in court productivity, we rerun our analysis to focus on the effects of transfers due to retirements rather than all transfers. As described in the research design section, judges retire at age 60. We therefore have reasons to believe that retirement transfers are orthogonal to the characteristics of the cases in that courtroom. Since most judges retire from District and Sessions courts, we first restrict our analysis—depicted in the middle panel of the first row—to these courts. The placebo effect is now much smaller. As before, transfers decrease the number of decisions issued by courts in the three months after, wherein the average total effect of transfers in this period is to decrease the

[16] The average cumulative or total effect of transfers is different from the sum of the coefficients because the average total effect is a weighted average of the individual dynamic treatment effects, where the weights are proportional to the number of units observed at each specific lag, rather than a simple unweighted sum.

number of decisions issued by 8.4, which amounts to 0.3 months of lost District and Sessions court productivity.

We plot the estimated effects of retirement transfers in District and Sessions courts in the top right panel of Figure 2. The placebo test for the month before transfers is insignificant.[17] Retirement transfers decrease the number of decisions issued by District and Sessions courts in the two months after transfers, with the negative effect in the second month being statistically distinguishable from zero. Retirement transfers decrease the average total or cumulative number of decisions issued by courts in the three months after by 8. Although similar in magnitude to the effects of all transfers, this estimate is statistically insignificant at conventional levels, possibly since only 1.8% of transfers are due to retirements. To the degree that frequent judge transfers demotivate judges in general—across the board, whether they are transferred or not—the estimated effects of transfers are likely to be a lower bound.

Across all three specifications, transfers cause courts to issue approximately 0.2–0.3 months of fewer decisions. The three estimates trade off precision against identification: the all-transfers estimate is the most precise but is subject to anticipation; the District and Sessions estimates exhibit little to no pre-trend; and the retirement estimate, while imprecise, is predetermined by judges' dates of birth. That designs with different threats to validity converge on the same magnitude constitutes our strongest courtroom-level evidence that transfers reduce productivity.

Decisions are the standard measure of judicial productivity, but they are not the only one. We re-estimate equation 1 using two further courtroom-month outcomes—the number of hearings held, and the ratio of hearings to decisions—and both reinforce the decisions result (see Appendix Figure B4 and Appendix Table B6). Hearings, too, fall in the months after a transfer (≈ 50 fewer by the third month), so transfers depress courtroom activity more broadly than the issuance of final decisions alone. The hearings-to-decisions ratio, by contrast, rises—peaking at about 40 in the

[17] This is consistent with retiring judges—unlike transferred judges, who face future annual performance evaluations—having weak incentives to clear their dockets before departing, and it suggests that the surge preceding ordinary transfers reflects career-motivated acceleration rather than differential trends across courtrooms.

second month—because decisions, the more demanding and more readily deferred task, decline proportionally more than hearings. In other words, transfers cause courtrooms to shift their output away from final adjudication and toward routine procedural work. This ratio is also better identified than the decisions outcome: its pre-treatment placebo is small and statistically insignificant, and its effect is positive and significant even for retirement transfers, our cleanest source of identifying variation.

Although our findings constitute the first systematic evidence that judge transfers undermine court productivity in India, they are consistent with a small practitioner and journalistic, qualitative literature that also posits a connection between transfers and case delays. For example, in a chapter on "the curse of the revolving docket," Thikkavarapu and Jain (2025) advances such an argument, providing readers with examples of delayed cases that experienced many judge transfers. In an online news article, Barnagarwala (2022) points to the egregious example of an as yet unresolved case that had been pending for over 36 years, and that had been assigned to approximately 12 judges. Judges too seem to be aware of the issue, with a High Court judge observing that transfers have "a serious telling repercussion on the disposal of the pending cases ... It becomes difficult to pinpoint the responsibility if the matter of enquiry is as to who was the officer who neglected to take up the old case. Moreover by the time a new officer familiarises himself with the pendency of the old cases and chalks out a phased programme to decide them, he is shifted to another court" (Allahabad High Court 1998).

To help explain why transfers decrease the number of decisions issued, we explore whether transfers increase courtroom vacancies. Our analysis is presented in the lower panels of Figure 2. Transfers are associated with a greater probability of subsequent vacancies, with the probability that a court was vacant increasing by 20 percentage points in the first month after transfers, and by 14–15 percentage points in the two months after. Since 6% of courtroom-months are on average vacant, these are substantively large effects. Retirement transfers are associated with similar albeit somewhat delayed effects. The vacancy results are particularly noteworthy since we expect vacancies in our administrative data to be undercounted. Vacancies could occur if new judges are not assigned to immediately substitute for old ones (we expect our data to reflect these de jure vacancies), and if newly assigned judges take time to start in their new positions (we do not expect the vacancy data to reflect these de facto vacancies). The estimated effects of judge transfers on decisions, vacancies, hearings and the ratio of hearings-to-decisions are apparent in the standard two-way fixed effects estimator too (see Appendix Tables B7 and B8).

In interviews, judges confirmed our statistical findings, noting that adjusting to new positions takes time and reduces judge productivity in the first few months after transfers (interview J5, August 2022). They also noted that judges with upcoming transfers might defer issuing decisions for cases that are fully heard (interview J1, May 2022), and further that they might defer hearings, particularly for difficult cases (interview J4, July 2022).

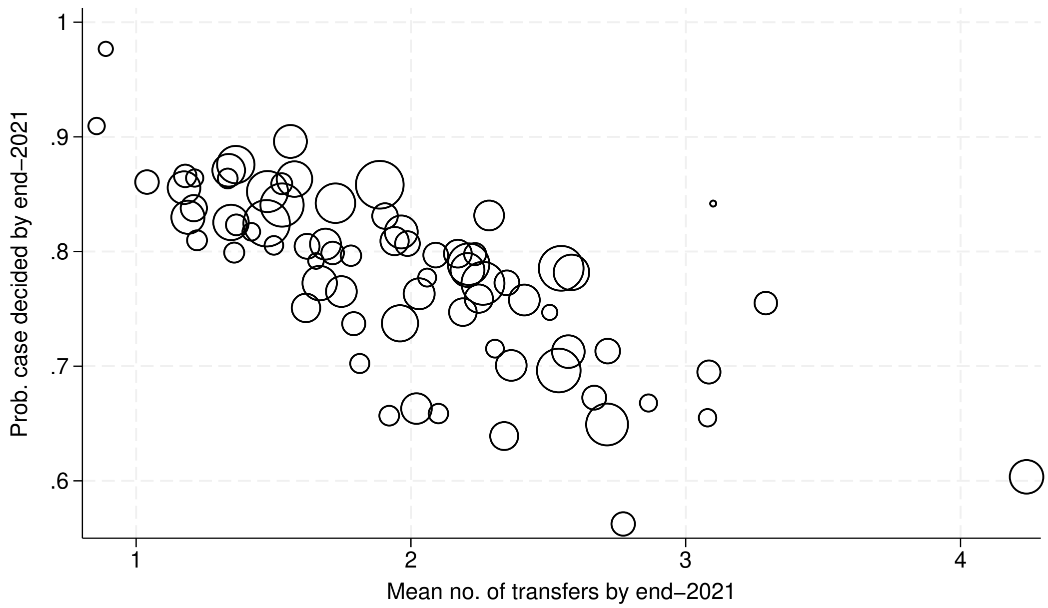
6 Transfers Reduce the Chances that Cases Are Decided

While our analysis thus far focused on court-level productivity, the welfare consequences of transfers are largely borne by the parties to cases. For a welfare analysis, the case and not the courtroom is therefore the relevant unit of analysis. Accordingly, we next turn to estimating the effect of transfers on the probability that the 6.4 million cases in our data will be decided.

We start by graphically examining the bivariate relationship between the mean transfers experienced by cases in Uttar Pradesh's districts and the probability that a case was decided. Both variables are measured as of end-2021. Figure 3 shows that the two are negatively correlated, suggesting that transfers worsen judicial decision-making.

To rigorously explore this relationship, we employ OLS regressions to estimate equation 2, as summarized in Table 1 (regressions with all covariates are in Appendix Tables B9 and B10). Regression 1 in Panel A replicates the negative bivariate relationship between transfers and the probability that a case is decided, illustrated in Figure 3. In the next regressions, we add the case-specific controls listed in the research design section, case-type fixed effects, courtroom fixed effects, their interactions, and filing month-year fixed effects. The fully saturated model, in column

Figure 3. Cases in districts with more transfers are less likely to be decided



Notes: Data are for Uttar Pradesh. Circle sizes are proportionate to the number of cases filed in each district.

4, suggests that transfers substantially slow decision-making: one judge transfer (that is, a 0.3 standard deviation increase in transfers) decreases the chances that a case will be decided by end-2021 by a statistically significant 9.2 percentage points or 11.8%.

The estimated effects of transfers on the probability that a case is decided by end-2021 are unlikely to be appreciably biased due to reverse causality. To see this, recall that we have approximately 6.4 million cases and cumulatively just 9,017 judge transfers. Even if each transfer occurs because of say two cases, the outcomes of 18,034 out of approximately 6.4 million cases (0.3%) would be biased. In other words, the scope for reverse causality is small.[18] That said, our analysis of transfers due to the retirement of judges at age 60 solves this issue. Since retirements are prompted by judges turning 60 and nothing else, reverse causality is a non-issue for this analysis.

[18] In addition, sensitivity analysis due to Cinelli and Hazlett (2020) as applied to our main specification with the treatment transformed into a dummy (see column 2 of Appendix Table B11) suggests that an omitted variable would have to explain at least 27.6% of the residual variation in the treatment and outcome to fully account for the observed estimated effect. Such a confounder is highly unlikely in that it would need to explain more than three times the variation explained by (1) case complexity (measured using the number of sections a case is filed under), (2) a dummy for whether the petitioner is female, or (3) a dummy for whether the state is the respondent.

Table 1. Transfers reduce the chances of a case being decided

	Case decided by end-2021 (0/1)				Judge vacancy (0/1)	No. of vacant spells	No. of hearings
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Panel A:							
transfer_out	-0.0975***	-0.0876***	-0.0929***	-0.0933***	0.0117***	0.0153***	3.396***
	(0.00210)	(0.00222)	(0.00244)	(0.00226)	(0.00112)	(0.00145)	(0.0789)
Observations	6421817	6421817	6421679	6421178	6421178	6421178	6386226
Adjusted R-squared	0.49	0.54	0.63	0.65	0.42	0.43	0.69
Panel B:							
Retirement transfer	0.0728***	0.0296	-0.0398**	-0.0449***	0.0930***	0.140***	4.041***
	(0.0211)	(0.0194)	(0.0197)	(0.0148)	(0.0192)	(0.0307)	(0.399)
transfer_outnor	-0.0978***	-0.0879***	-0.0931***	-0.0935***	0.0114***	0.0149***	3.394***
	(0.00211)	(0.00224)	(0.00246)	(0.00227)	(0.00111)	(0.00144)	(0.0792)
Observations	6421817	6421817	6421679	6421178	6421178	6421178	6386226
Adjusted R-squared	0.49	0.54	0.63	0.65	0.42	0.43	0.69
Dependent variable mean	0.78	0.78	0.78	0.78	0.08	0.09	12.05
Case-specific controls		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Act fixed effects		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Case type fixed effects		✓	✓				
Courtroom fixed effects			✓				
Case type X courtroom fixed effects				✓	✓	✓	✓
Filing month-year fixed effects			✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Notes: Case-specific controls are the number of sections to which cases refer (with a missing-data indicator), indicators for bailable and nonbailable crimes, and indicators for the parties' gender (with missing-data indicators) and whether they are the government. Standard errors clustered by courtroom for regressions in columns 1–3; standard errors are clustered by case type X courtroom for the regressions in columns 4–7. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

To confirm that transfers do indeed *cause* case delays, we disaggregate the total transfers variable into transfers due to retirements and for other reasons. The results of the fully saturated model (Panel B, regression 4) suggest that transfers due to retirements reduce the probability of a case being decided by 5.2 percentage points or 6.6%. Although smaller than the effect of other transfers estimated in the same regression, the effects of retirement transfers are substantively and statistically significant.

Because older and more complex cases may both accumulate more transfers and be less likely to be decided by end-2021, our main analyses control for filing month-year fixed effects and case complexity, and leverage retirement transfers. As a further check, Appendix Table B12 re-estimates equation 2 as a set of fixed-horizon duration models (Beck et al. 1998; Carter and Signorino 2010). We measure transfers and the outcome within the same one-, two-, and three-year windows from filing, so that no case accumulates transfers beyond the common horizon at which all cases are compared. The estimates are, if anything, larger: an additional transfer in the first year after filing reduces the probability of a decision within that year by 33%, and the effect remains large and significant at 17% within three years. Put differently, the marginal transfer increases the probability that a case takes more than three years to conclude by 50%—transfers are most disruptive early in a case's life. The Kaplan–Meier curves in Appendix Figure B5 show the same pattern descriptively: cases with more transfers remain undecided for longer at every duration since filing.

Our results are robust to clustering standard errors at the court rather than case type X courtroom level (this helps account for the correlation between within-court transfers induced by the seniority rule) and to re-specifying the transfer variables as dummies, logging them, and winsorizing them too (Appendix Table B11). Specifying the years-to-decision as the dependent variable (see Appendix Table B13) also yields consistent results, although by definition the latter analysis can only use data on decided cases.

In Table 2, we examine the heterogeneity in the effect of transfers, showing that the negative effects of transfers are mostly stable across case and court types (regressions with all covariates are in Appendix Tables B14 and B15). In columns 1–4, we examine the degree to which transfers affect cases that are classified into the mutually exclusive, collectively exhaustive categories of civil, criminal, bail and unclassified cases (see Appendix A for coding rules). Transfers decrease the chances of all case types being decided by end-2021, with transfers having similar effects in percent terms on civil and criminal cases. Transfers have a much smaller effect on bail cases, a finding to which we return later.

In columns 5–9, we examine the varying effects of transfers across courts ordered from junior to senior, starting with Junior Division courts and ending with District and Sessions courts and Family courts, which are the senior-most courts in a district and from which judges typically retire. We find that judge transfers are more disruptive to cases filed in junior courts: whereas an additional transfer decreases the chance of a case being decided by 18% in the Civil Judge Junior Division courts, they decrease the chances of a case being decided by end-2021 by 6–8% in the District and Sessions courts and Family courts.

To examine the mechanisms by which transfers undermine court productivity, we draw on our theory to test whether transfers trigger two of the mechanisms posited therein. First, do transfers cause cases to be unassigned to judges for brief spells, and second, do they cause cases to require additional hearings before being decided.

Column 5 of Table 1 suggests that an additional transfer increases the chances of a case experiencing any vacancy by 16%. Column 6 suggests a similarly large effect if we employ the number of vacancies as the outcome variable. As before, the results are robust to using retirement transfers as the key independent variable. These results are consistent with the courtroom analysis, which showed that transfers increase the chances of a courtroom-level vacancy.

We also test whether transfers cause cases to have more hearings, thereby contributing to judicial delays. While the average case in our data has 12 hearings, regression 7 suggests that each additional transfer causes 3.3 or 27% more hearings (the estimates are larger for retirement transfers). These results are consistent with interviews, wherein judges confirmed that transfers do

Table 2. Heterogeneous treatment effects by case type (columns 1–4) and court type (columns 5–9)

	Case decided (0/1)								
Sample:	Civil cases	Criminal cases	Bail cases	Unclassified cases	Civil judge Junior div	Civil judge Senior div	Chief Judicial Magistrate	District and Sessions courts	Family courts
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
Panel A:									
Number of transfers	-0.0836***	-0.0972***	-0.0149***	-0.0669***	-0.113***	-0.0889***	-0.0991***	-0.0689***	-0.0604***
	(0.00232)	(0.00309)	(0.00307)	(0.00381)	(0.00625)	(0.00330)	(0.00388)	(0.00192)	(0.00469)
Observations	768281	3912472	833863	908694	669153	384950	3411833	1492512	352337
Adjusted R-squared	0.57	0.67	0.16	0.54	0.61	0.66	0.69	0.65	0.28
Panel B:									
Number of retirement transfers	-0.0475**	-0.104***	-0.00925	-0.0163				-0.0224	-0.00742
	(0.0240)	(0.0190)	(0.00801)	(0.0311)				(0.0182)	(0.0134)
Number of other transfers	-0.0840***	-0.0971***	-0.0150***	-0.0672***	-0.113***	-0.0889***	-0.0991***	-0.0694***	-0.0617***
	(0.00236)	(0.00311)	(0.00312)	(0.00384)	(0.00625)	(0.00330)	(0.00388)	(0.00195)	(0.00483)
Observations	768281	3912472	833863	908694	669153	384950	3411833	1492512	352337
Adjusted R-squared	0.57	0.67	0.16	0.54	0.61	0.66	0.69	0.65	0.28
Mean dependent variable	0.65	0.74	1.00	0.88	0.63	0.79	0.77	0.86	0.93

Notes: The independent variables are defined as transfers until end-2021. All regressions control for the number of sections to which cases refer (with a missing-data indicator), indicators for bailable and nonbailable crimes, indicators for the parties' gender (with missing-data indicators) and whether they are the government, act fixed effects, case type X courtroom fixed effects, and filing month-year fixed effects. Judges retire from the District and Sessions courts and Family courts. Standard errors clustered by case type X courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

indeed slow down cases by causing arguments to be re-heard. In an interview, one judge noted: "There have been cases that have been heard by 10 judges, and still no decision has been issued. If a judge is transferred after arguments have been heard once, sometimes – but not always – arguments need to be re-heard" (interview J1, May 2022). Another judge noted that "Most orders require to be re-heard – a new judge may have a new angle to a case" (interview J3, July 2022).

Together, these results provide support for both hypothesized mechanisms: transfers increase the chances that a case is unassigned to a judge for a while, and increase the total number of hearings experienced by cases.

7 Reducing the Negative Effects of Transfers

Our analysis suggests that transfers reduce courtroom productivity and increase case delays. Any policy proposal to reduce transfer frequency, however, must weigh these costs against the system's benefits. While relaxing the seniority principle, or limiting its application to within courts rather than court types so as to trigger fewer cascading transfers, would mechanically reduce the number of transfers, such structural reforms may also not be politically feasible. We therefore focus on the more immediate solutions suggested by our theory to mitigate the costs of transfers, holding their frequency constant.

First, consider the benefits of better staggering transfers. In Uttar Pradesh, 40% of transfers occur in one batch in April or May due to an Annual Transfer exercise. The remaining transfers occur in a staggered manner throughout the year. In interviews, judges noted the disruptive potential of mass or batch annual transfers (interview J5, August 2022). To test this prediction, we re-estimate equation 2 by disaggregating the transfers into staggered and mass transfers. Regression 1 in Table 3 suggests that while both kinds of transfers reduce the probability that a case is decided by end-2021, the negative effect of mass transfers is 24% greater than the effect of staggered transfers (regressions with all covariates are in Appendix Table B16). The difference in the estimated effects of mass and staggered transfers is substantively and statistically significant, although the effect of staggered

Table 3. Possible fixes: Staggering transfers and rules for the time-bound disposal of cases attenuate the negative effects of transfers

	Case decided (0/1)	Judge vacancy (0/1)	No. of vacant spells	No. of hearings	Case decided (0/1)	
	1	2	3	4	5	6
Number of mass transfers	-0.112***	0.00654*	0.00763*	3.940***		
	(0.00657)	(0.00375)	(0.00440)	(0.204)		
Number of staggered transfers	-0.0847***	0.0140***	0.0186***	3.145***		
	(0.00273)	(0.00217)	(0.00256)	(0.0958)		
Number of transfers					-0.0932***	
					(0.00227)	
Number of transfers X Bail cases					0.0862***	
					(0.00397)	
Number of retirement transfers						-0.0471***
						(0.0152)
Number of retirement transfers X Bail cases						-0.0167
						(0.0195)
Number of other transfers						-0.0933***
						(0.00229)
Number of other transfers X Bail cases						0.0877***
						(0.00407)
Observations	6423310	6423310	6423310	6388360	6423310	6423310
Adjusted R-squared	0.65	0.42	0.43	0.69	0.65	0.65
Mean dependent variable	0.78	0.08	0.09	12.05	0.78	0.78

Notes: The independent variables are defined as transfers until end-2021. All regressions control for the number of sections to which cases refer (with a missing-data indicator), indicators for bailable and nonbailable crimes, indicators for the parties' gender (with missing-data indicators) and whether they are the government, act fixed effects, case type X courtroom fixed effects, and filing month-year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by case type X courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

transfers is also significantly different from zero. This suggests that spreading transfers throughout the year could attenuate their negative effects. Lastly, both further implications of our account are borne out in the subsequent regressions: relative to staggered transfers, mass transfers are less likely to cause vacancies (this is consistent with their being planned) but cause more hearings (this is consistent with the strain that simultaneous turnover places on court staff).

Rules also appear to help. As in other countries, strong norms ensure that bail cases in India are resolved quickly. Consistent with this, regression 5 suggests that transfers do not impede the disposition of bail cases. Regression 6 suggests that this pattern is apparent when considering retirement and other transfers.[19] Since bail cases differ from others on many dimensions, we interpret this heterogeneity as consistent with our theory rather than as a causal estimate of time-bound disposal rules or norms. Testing rules directly requires variation in the rules themselves, which we leave to future work.

Importantly, the policy implications of these findings—undertake staggered rather than mass transfers, and require cases be decided quickly—do not necessitate fewer transfers per se, but rather suggest ways to reduce the negative effects of transfers, whatever their frequency. Nor do they require re-politicizing assignments: neither reform gives anyone discretion over which judge sits where, so both preserve the insulating function of the existing rules.

8 External Validity

We are able to confirm that our results on the effects of transfers on productivity travel to other parts of India. To show this, recall that Figure 1 showed that lower court judges are transferred frequently across the country. In other words, the problem of frequent transfers is endemic to the lower judiciary nationwide. To examine the productivity effects of transfers, we draw on the case-level data released by Ash et al. (2025), which—for about 11.7% of cases filed between 2015 and 2018—notes the judge that the case was filed under and the judge that the case was decided under. This allows us to code whether each decided case experienced a transfer,[20] but not the precise number of transfers. In Appendix Table B17, we model the time to decision as a function of whether the case experienced at least one transfer and courtroom and filing month-year fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the courtroom level. The saturated model in column 3 suggests that cases that experience a transfer take an additional year to be decided. The model in column 4 shows that this effect is positive and significant in every state, ranging from 0.6 to 1.3 years.[21] Since this analysis lacks the detailed case-level controls available for Uttar Pradesh, our estimates

[19] The smaller effect on bail cases is unlikely to reflect ceiling effects alone, as the pattern is apparent when using time to decision as the outcome variable.

[20] We thank Nirvikar Jassal for noting this.

[21] In this specification, transfers increased the time to decision in Uttar Pradesh by 0.95 years. Using the same specification on our data yields a broadly comparable estimate of 1.4 years.

may be more susceptible to confounding, and should therefore be interpreted as suggestive of the generalizability of our findings rather than as precise causal estimates.

Our theory predicts that transfers will reduce productivity when there is a large stock of pending cases, and when judges—rather than juries—control the pace of case disposal. These conditions are present in many judicial systems worldwide. While the cascading transfers we document are specific to Uttar Pradesh's seniority-based assignment system, the productivity costs of transfers arise from vacancies and additional hearings, which do not depend on the cause of the transfer. Some empirical evidence supports this prediction. In Italy, Guerra and Tagliapietra (2017) shows that judge changes reduce case disposal rates, and a recent practitioner study found that they extend the duration of real estate enforcement cases by 37% (T6 Association 2025). In Spain, Rosales-López (2008) finds that judicial turnover reduces the number of resolutions in Andalusian civil courts, and Moral et al. (2025) document similar effects in Spanish labor courts. In Nepal, Grajzl and Silwal (2020) show that multi-court judging caused by rotation slows case resolution.

Beyond these quantitative studies, practitioner and journalistic accounts from other countries are consistent with our findings. In Kenya, the Law Society warned that mass magistrate transfers could delay justice by up to two years (Orina 2016; Standard Team 2015). In the United States, North Carolina's constitutionally mandated six-month rotation of superior court judges was identified as sufficiently disruptive that the state created a specialized Business Court in 1995 partly to exempt complex cases from it (O'Brien 2002; Paschal 1948). Japan rotates judges every two to three years (Ramseyer 1994), and China has a similar practice (Zhu 2024), though quantitative evidence on productivity effects in those contexts remains limited.

More broadly, the logic of our theory—that the frequent transfer of bureaucrats might undermine productivity—extends beyond judiciaries to bureaucracies where officers manage ongoing caseloads, such as tax administration or regulatory enforcement. The institutional logic travels too: rule-based transfers and backfilling are common features of insulated personnel systems—in militaries and foreign services that rotate officers on fixed cycles, in civil-service seniority systems, and in auditor-rotation mandates adopted to prevent capture—suggesting that the trade-off we document between insulation and operational capacity is general. We leave empirical investigation of those settings to future work.

9 Discussion and Conclusion

We have theorized and shown—using a variety of research designs—that judge transfers are frequent, and that they slow judicial decision-making. These findings help explain significant case delays and high pendency rates in India.[22] Our results are likely to travel to other parts of the country and world, including to countries as diverse as Italy, Spain, Nepal and Kenya where transfers are frequent, there are large stocks of pending cases, and judges set the pace for case disposal.

The estimated effects of transfers are large. The average transfer—which for the average judge in Uttar Pradesh occurs once every seven months—causes a courtroom to issue approximately 8–10 fewer decisions, equivalent to 0.2–0.3 months of lost productivity, an estimate that is consistent across designs that use all transfers and only those prompted by mandatory retirements. Transfers slow decision-making as they create courtroom vacancies and increase the hearings needed to decide cases. Better planning and rules for the time-bound disposal of cases can attenuate the negative effect of transfers: staggered transfers have less pernicious effects than mass ones, and bail cases—which are decided quickly—are less affected by transfers.

Why are transfers so frequent in India? Our analysis suggests that approximately a third of transfers are cascading reassignments triggered by the seniority rule. This rule is a classic depoliticizing mechanism or "anti-politics machine" (Ferguson 1994), intended to safeguard judicial independence. That the seniority rule ironically amplifies transfer frequency, and thereby degrades court productivity, illustrates how rigid, top-down rules can be counterproductive for complex tasks such as delivering justice (Honig 2018; Mangla 2024; Scott 2020), even as they might have

[22] Recall that we had estimated that the average transfer decreased the chances that a case was decided by 9.2 percentage points. Since the average case experienced 1.98 transfers, our estimates suggest that transfers will have caused 18.3 percentage points of cases to be pending as of end-2021. Although this calculation assumes no general equilibrium effects, it is close to the pendency rate of 22% in our data.

some benefits in terms of depoliticizing judge assignments. Notably, the productivity costs of transfers arise from vacancies and additional hearings—mechanisms that operate regardless of what triggers a transfer—and are therefore not specific to systems with seniority-based cascading. Variation across India's High Courts in how strictly they apply seniority-based assignment—and the corresponding variation in judge tenure documented in Figure 1—offers a natural setting for future work to test this institutional account directly.

Although transfers could, in principle, reduce judge corruption, increase judicial independence, or broaden judicial experience, it is not clear whether these potential benefits justify the high costs of frequent transfers, particularly when other judiciaries secure these benefits without frequent transfers. Moreover, while any reassignment separates a judge from specific pending cases, the bulk of the turnover we document moves judges within districts, where local ties remain intact, and is therefore difficult to justify on anti-corruption grounds. Due to space and data constraints, we leave a direct test of the benefits of transfers to future work. Other studies could also examine variation in judge transfer practices across and within countries.

Comparing the effects of reducing transfers to the effects of hiring more judges, which is a frequently prescribed solution to high case pendency across the developing world, is instructive. Hiring judges requires budgetary outlays and has proved to be difficult in India, including because of the tendency of the exams to be delayed due to litigation (Chandrashekaran et al. 2024). In contrast, reducing judge transfers does not require additional funds and is arguably easier. In Uttar Pradesh, reducing transfers from once every seven months to once every two years—assuming linearity and no general equilibrium effects—would be the equivalent of hiring 52 judges.[23] This is a substantial effect, particularly since the "working strength" of Uttar Pradesh's lower courts increased by a mere 77 judges between 2020 and 2025 despite having over 1,000 vacancies. Notably, because cross-

[23] To see this, note that judges are currently transferred an average of once every 7 months or 1.7 times a year. Reducing this to once every two years or 0.5 times a year would reduce transfers by 71%. In our data, there were 3,731 transfers in 2018. Since the average transfer causes courts to issue 10.47 fewer decisions in the three months after the transfer (for this guesstimate, we use the estimates from the first model in Figure 2; since all three models in this Figure suggest that judges lose approximately 0.2–0.3 months of productivity due to transfers, similar results obtain if we use the other models), reducing the number of transfers by 71% would—assuming linearity and no general equilibrium effects—increase the number of decisions issued by 27,735, which is the annual output of 52 judges.

district rotation and its cascades account for only about a fifth of transfers, such a reduction could be achieved while retaining the anti-entrenchment rule that judges be transferred across districts once every three years.

A major innovation of our study is to extend the study of the bureaucracy, which has thus far focused on the executive, to the judiciary. In so doing, we show that judges suffer from the same pathology—frequent transfers—as do bureaucrats in many countries. Although the literature on bureaucratic transfers has suggested the possible negative consequences of frequent transfers, it has difficulty estimating such effects because bureaucratic output is varied and is therefore difficult to measure systematically. Since all judges decide cases, switching focus to judges solves this problem, allowing us to document some of the welfare costs of frequent transfers.

Our paper furthers the small, new, data-driven literature on the Indian judicial system, extending it to the major and understudied issue of judicial delays. Whereas much of the policy literature on judicial delays notes that the system is severely underresourced, we show that the system can do more with its existing resources by simply reducing the frequency of judge transfers, which would boost court productivity. Further, we show that even with the current frequency of transfers, staggering them throughout the year and adopting time-bound disposal rules can attenuate their costs.

The problem of judicial delays is not unique to India but plagues rich and poor countries worldwide. By tracing the effects of the frequent transfer of judges on case disposals, we extend the broader comparative literature on this issue, which has focused on the effects of factors such as technology and case complexity. In contrast, we argue that a major cause of judicial delays is the seemingly innocuous frequent transfer of judges.

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Appendix for "Musical Chairs: Frequent Judge Transfers Undermine Court Productivity in India"

A Data Appendix

We analyze two datasets: a case-level dataset of individual cases and a courtroom-month panel. Both are built from three inputs—the case records, the judge-positions panel, and the coding of transfer types—which we describe in turn before explaining how each dataset is assembled.

A.1 Case records

Obtaining cases. We collect case data for every district court in Uttar Pradesh from the Indian eCourts platform[1]—a public-facing website with case- and hearing-level data on all cases filed in the courts—beginning from the list of case identifiers (CINOs) for cases filed between 2015 and 2018 compiled by Ash et al. (2025).

Augmenting the records. For each CINO we re-scrape the eCourts platform to augment the Ash et al. (2025) data with hearing-level, case-level, and courtroom metadata. The case-level metadata includes information on litigants. The courtroom-level metadata lets us match each case to the courtrooms to which it was assigned over time. We used the resources of the Center for High Throughput Computing at our University to run Python scripts that submitted each CINO to one of the 74 district (dcourts) websites and saved the raw HTML, which we then cleaned and organized to produce a preliminary case-level dataset.

De-duplication. Because cases moved from one court to another are typically assigned new identification numbers, we reconcile records that refer to the same case. When a case moves across courtrooms within the same court type, no new number is assigned. When a case moves across court types—for example, from a Judicial Magistrate to a Chief Judicial Magistrate court—it receives a new number. In 2023 the eCourts website added a mapping linking each new number to its original, which we scraped and use to consolidate such records into a single case identifier, from which we determine each case's filing date, decision status, and decision date.

Classifying cases. We classify each case as civil, non-bail criminal, or bail using the case type, act, section, and FIR details, with civil and criminal mutually exclusive. Cases under the Civil Procedure Code are civil, while those under the Indian Penal Code or Criminal Procedure Code are non-bail criminal or bail. About 12% of cases are civil, 61% non-bail criminal, and 13% bail. The remaining 14% fall in a residual "unclassified" category. We also draw on Ash et al. (2025) to code whether the underlying offense is bailable or non-bailable, and the gender of the parties (this relied on a neural-net gender classifier). For each case, we clean the act under which it is filed and count the number of sections. Finally, we code whether the state—the UP or Indian Government—is the petitioner or respondent.

Coding decisions. We code a case as decided if we observe a decision date before 31 December 2021.

A.2 Creating judge-positions panel to identify transfers

Source: We also obtain data on judges in the Uttar Pradesh District Courts, which is used to calculate our main independent variable on transfers. We obtain these from two sources: first, from the website of the Allahabad High Court, and second, from the eCourts platform.

[1] Source: `https://services.ecourts.gov.in/ecourtindia_v6/`.

Judge profile data from the Allahabad High Court's website includes detailed data on judge profiles—this includes information about a judge's background, including their date of joining, date of promotions, gender, qualifications, and importantly, the date of retirement. Since this information is not available for retired judges, we first tried to obtain this data by filing requests under the "Right to Information" Act. Our request was rejected, so we scraped this data from the Wayback Machine in January 2026, which allowed us to obtain judge profiles data for both current and retired judges. To do this, we first scraped the entire history of each available update to the 74 District Court web pages. Each instance of a District Court web page shows the judges currently serving in the court, with links to their profile pages. Once we assembled all the links to judge profiles, we used the Wayback Machine API to obtain the latest, most comprehensive version of the judge's profile. This gives us judge profiles to 2,987 judges.

Data from the eCourts platform includes the judge's name, their designations, and the start and end dates of appointments as assigned to a courtroom. This information, on the start and end dates of courtrooms that judges were presiding, allows us to link the judge data back to cases. We matched each judge name to the scraped judge profiles data, with a 96% match rate. This allows us to learn precisely when judges were promoted and retired.

Transfers: We use the information on judges' start and end dates in each courtroom from the eCourts data to create our main independent variable on transfers. We use the end date of a judge in a courtroom to determine that a judge has been moved out of a courtroom in a given month and year. We use this panel of judge positions to compute whether a courtroom experiences a transfer during a month-year, and to compute whether a case experiences a transfer. This data was scraped from the District Courts (dcourts) website in May 2022, by selecting a dropdown for each court complex to get a list of all judges who had served in courtrooms within the complex.

Courtroom level: A court experiences a transfer during a month-year if our judge-position data captures an end in a judge's position in that courtroom during the month-year.

Case level: We count the number of transfers (number of judges transferred out of a courtroom) experienced by a case from its filing date to end-2021 (if the case is undecided) or from its filing date to the decision date (if the case is decided). In rare instances, a judge who is transferred takes pending cases to the new courtroom. If a case moves to another courtroom with the same judge in a consecutive spell, the move is not coded as a transfer, since no change in the judge assigned to the case has occurred.

A.3 Coding transfer types

The distribution of transfers presented in Section 4 is derived using a combination of observed counts and regression estimates. As described below, we classify transfers into six mutually exclusive, collectively exhaustive categories. When a transfer is of more than one type, we assign it to the one representing the most consequential change in the judge's status: retirement or recruitment, then promotion, then deputation, then inter-district transfer. The first five are directly observed; the sixth is a residual. The transfer categories are (1) recruitment transfers (2.9% of all transfers), which occur as new judges are inducted into the judiciary, (2) promotion transfers (7.5%), which occur due to promotions from the junior to the senior division, from the senior division to the District and Sessions level, and from the District and Sessions level to the High Court level, (3) inter-district transfers (14.0%), (4) deputation transfers (4.2%), (5) retirement transfers (1.8%), (6) other/administrative transfers.

To estimate the cascading effect of each transfer type, we collapse our courtroom-month data to the district–court type–month level and regress total transfers on contemporaneous and lagged counts of the five types of transfers we directly observe (that is, all transfers except for the residual category), with district–court type and month-year fixed effects. We include one monthly lag because cascading reassignments triggered by the seniority rule typically resolve within the same month as the primary transfer, or at most the following month. Standard errors are clustered by district–court type. Since each primary transfer mechanically contributes 1 to total transfers, the additional transfers triggered by the seniority-based reshuffling or cascade is the sum of the contemporaneous and lagged coefficients minus 1. The results, presented in regression 1 of Table A1, show that the five observed transfer types trigger upto 0.57 cascading transfers each. Pooling the five types and interacting total primary transfers with standardized court size, the implied cascade increases by 0.16 reassignments per standard deviation of court size, consistent with chains propagating through more same-level positions in larger courts.

We use these regression estimates to decompose the total number of transfers into primary and cascading components. For the observed types of transfers, we multiply each transfer type's cascade rate by the observed number of primary transfers to obtain the implied number of cascading transfers. For the residual "other administrative" category—which includes within-district transfers for administrative reasons and professional development—we apply the inter-district transfer cascade rate of 0.49 (this is practically identical to the weighted average cascade rate across all observed transfer types of 0.50), since both types occur across all court types and levels and are likely to trigger similar seniority-based cascades.

Table A2 presents the resulting decomposition. We estimate that approximately 33.1% of all transfers are cascading, triggered by the seniority-based reshuffling that follows a primary transfer.[2] The remaining 66.9% are primary transfers prompted by judge recruitment, promotions, inter-district transfers, deputations, retirements and other administrative needs.

From the judge profiles (scraped from the Allahabad High Court) and the judge-positions panel, we code each of the five observed transfer types. *Recruitment* transfers are coded when a newly recruited judge—inducted at the Civil Judge Junior Division or Additional District Judge level—is assigned to a courtroom and displaces the sitting judge. *Promotion* transfers use the profile dates of elevation from the junior to the senior division, from the senior division to the District and Sessions level, and—using the Allahabad High Court's elevation list—from the District and Sessions level to the High Court. *Inter-district* transfers are identified from a judge's next position in the panel. *Deputation* transfers use the start dates of judges' deputations to non-courtroom roles such as registrars, secretaries, and members of statutory bodies and judicial commissions. *Retirement* transfers use the precise retirement dates in the profiles. At the case level, we count the number of transfers of each type that a case experiences between its filing date and its decision date (or

[2] Our estimates of cascading transfers are likely underestimates because transfer cascades occur in courts that judges are transferred out of and into. Since the regression analysis in Appendix Table A1 uses the district–court type as the unit of analysis, the cascades in destination courts are accounted for only when they are to the same district–court type. Therefore, cascading effects of promotions and inter-district transfers in destination courts are not accounted for.

Table A1. Transfers trigger cascading reassignments and cascades are increasing in court size

Outcome: Total transfers	1
Retirements	0.842***
	(0.0927)
Retirements lagged	0.723***
	(0.172)
Recruitments	1.059***
	(0.0619)
Recruitments lagged	-0.180***
	(0.0521)
Promotions	1.554***
	(0.0572)
Promotions lagged	-0.0518*
	(0.0291)
Deputations	1.497***
	(0.115)
Deputations lagged	0.0485
	(0.0555)
Inter-district transfers	1.568***
	(0.0531)
Inter-district transfers lagged	-0.0593*
	(0.0331)
Observations	17128
Adjusted R-squared	0.54
Implied cascade:	
Retirements	0.57***
Recruitments	-0.12
Promotions	0.50***
Deputations	0.55***
Inter-district transfers	0.51***
Cascade gradient (per SD of court size):	
Pooled across transfer types	0.16***

Notes: The unit of observation is the district–court type–month. The dependent variable is the total number of transfers out. All estimates include district–court type and month-year fixed effects, with standard errors clustered by district–court type. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. The implied cascade rows report the sum of each transfer type's contemporaneous and lagged coefficients, minus one. The cascade gradient row is from a separate regression that pools the five transfer types and interacts total primary transfers and their lag with standardized court size. It reports the sum of the two interaction terms, which yields the additional cascading reassignments per transfer associated with a one standard deviation increase in court size. A positive gradient indicates that vacancy chains propagate further in districts with more same-level courtrooms.

Table A2. Consolidated transfer distribution

Transfer type	Primary (%)	Cascading (%)	Total (%)
Recruitment	2.9	2.9	5.8
Promotion	7.5	2.9	10.4
Inter-district	14.0	6.9	20.8
Deputation	4.2	1.6	5.8
Retirement	1.8	0.9	2.7
Other/Administrative	36.6	17.9	54.5
Total	66.9	33.1	100.0

Notes: Primary transfer counts for recruitment, promotions, inter-district transfers, deputations and retirements are observed directly in the courtroom-month dataset. Cascading transfers for these types are estimated by multiplying the cascade rate from Table A1 by the number of primary transfers. The cascade rate for other administrative transfers is assumed to equal the cascade rate for inter-district transfers (0.49), since both types occur across all court types and levels. See text for details.

end-2021 if it remains undecided).

Mass and Staggered Transfers

We obtained data from the Allahabad High Court for information on transfer cycles. Typically, judges are transferred away from their districts every 2-3 years.

Courtroom level: We code the transfer cycles for each year using the notifications shared by the Allahabad High Court each year. We document the entire transfer cycle for mass transfers each year from 2015 to 2018. Specifically, for each year, we note the month when the transfer notification was released, when the transfer orders announcement was made, and the date by which the new position would need to be taken up. This allows us to code each transfer as either a part of a mass transfer or a staggered transfer.

We code that a courtroom experiences a mass transfer during the month-year, based on the month in which the new positions need to be taken up, as per the Annual Transfer Cycle. That is, mass transfers are those that occurred in April 2015, May 2016, May 2017, and April 2018.

Case level: For each transfer that a case experienced, depending on the month-year, we classify them as being mass transfers or staggered transfers. The mass transfers are the number of transfers that occurred in April 2015, May 2016, May 2017, April 2018, April 2019, and April 2021 (there were no mass transfers in 2020 on account of the COVID-19 pandemic), whereas staggered transfers are those that occurred in other months.

A.4 Constructing the two analysis datasets

We combine the case records with the transfer counts from the judge-positions panel and transfer coding to build the two datasets we analyze.

Case-level dataset. After de-duplication we have the universe of unique cases filed in Uttar Pradesh between 2015 and 2018, which serves as the baseline for the case-level analysis. From this baseline we apply three exclusions: we drop cases whose post-2018 transfers we cannot follow (because the Development Data Lab universe of CINOs ends in 2018), cases with filing- or transfer-date inconsistencies, and cases whose transfer histories are likely undercounted. Figure A1 reports the sample remaining at each step, from the raw CINO list through de-duplication to the final analysis sample. To each retained case we attach the number of transfers it experienced—in total and by type (retirement, mass, and staggered)—computed from the judge-positions panel as described above.

Figure A1. Construction of the case-level analysis sample

Total CINOs from Ash et al. (2025), 2015–2018
Remaining sample: 8,740,851

↓

Re-scraped case metadata to obtain courtroom information
Remaining sample: 7,729,722

↓

Harmonized CINOs to identify unique cases
Remaining sample: 7,502,698

↓

Excluded cases with new CINOs filed after 2018
Remaining sample: 7,455,730

↓

Excluded cases with filing- or transfer-date inconsistencies
Retained cases with updated dates between 2015 and 2018
Remaining sample: 7,011,464

↓

Excluded cases with potentially undercounted transfers
Final case-level analysis sample: 6,391,356

Notes: The first three rows build the baseline of unique cases (re-scraping and de-duplication). The final three rows are the analytical exclusions whose selectivity is assessed in Appendix Table A3.

We treat these three exclusions as the attrition in the case-level sample and ask whether it is selective. Appendix Table A3 reports the characteristics we condition on for the de-duplicated baseline and the analysis sample. If the analysis sample tracks the baseline, the attrition is not selecting on these observables. Our preferred estimates additionally leverage retirement transfers, whose timing is fixed by a judge's age and therefore orthogonal to case characteristics, providing a further safeguard against any residual selectivity.

Table A3. Balance of case characteristics across the de-duplicated baseline and the analysis sample

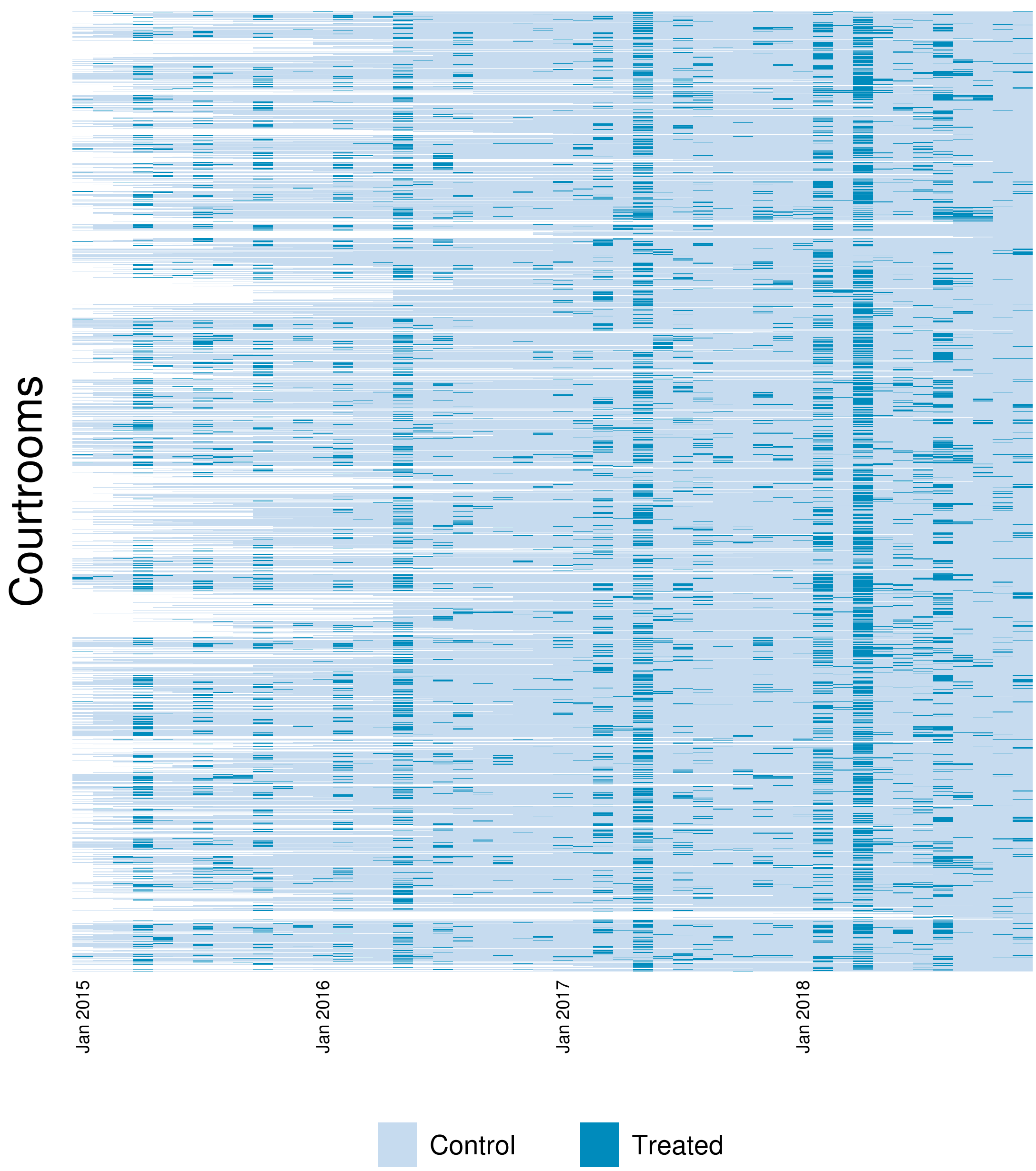
	De-duplicated sample	Analysis sample
Case decided (0/1)		
Number of sections		
Sections missing		
Bailable crime		
Nonbailable crime		
Petitioner: State		
Petitioner: Government of India		
Petitioner: Uttar Pradesh		
Petitioner: Female		
Petitioner: Gender missing		
Respondent: State		
Respondent: Government of India		
Respondent: Uttar Pradesh		
Respondent: Female		
Respondent: Gender missing		
Filing year		
Observations		

Notes: The table reports means for the de-duplicated baseline of unique cases filed in 2015–2018 ("De-duplicated sample") and the case-level analysis sample ("Analysis sample"). Variables are the case characteristics conditioned on in the case-level regressions. The number of transfers are omitted because they cannot be measured for the excluded cases (by construction for the undercounted-transfer exclusion). See text for details.

Courtroom-month panel. For the courtroom-month panel we retain a broader set of cases, since courtroom outcomes only require that a filing, hearing, or decision be observed in a courtroom-month. We drop cases transferred (assigned a new CINO) after 2018, whose post-transfer courtroom and decision status we cannot follow, and restrict to cases filed between 2015 and 2018. We then summarize filings, decisions, hearings, and other outcomes for each courtroom and merge them with the courtroom transfers data, matching 99.8% of cases to courtrooms for which we observe transfers; this brings the total to 7.19 million filings. Aggregating these outcomes by month yields a panel of 2,518 courtrooms observed between 2015 and 2018, onto which we merge the number of transfers—in total and by type—in each courtroom-month.

B Supplemental Figures and Tables

Figure B1. Distribution of transfers across courtrooms and over time



Source: Own calculations, based on the courtroom-month dataset.

Table B1. Summary statistics for Uttar Pradesh courtroom-level analysis

	Obs.	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min.	Max.
Number of cases decided	97,080	44.22	133.46	0	5615
Transfer month	97,080	0.09	0.29	0	1
Retirement transfer month	97,080	0.00	0.04	0	1
Courtroom vacant (0/1)?	97,080	0.06	0.25	0	1

Notes: The data include one observation for each courtroom-month-year between 2015 and 2018.

Table B2. Summary statistics for Uttar Pradesh case-level analysis

	Obs.	Mean	Std. Dev.	Min.	Max.
Prob. case decided by end-2021	6,424,114	0.78	0.41	0	1
Prob. case decided within 1 year of filing	6,424,114	0.59	0.49	0	1
Prob. case decided within 2 years of filing	6,424,114	0.69	0.46	0	1
Prob. case decided within 3 years of filing	6,424,114	0.74	0.44	0	1
Prob. case experienced a vacancy	6,424,114	0.08	0.26	0	1
Number of vacant spells	6,424,114	0.09	0.35	0	8
Number of transfers	6,424,114	1.98	2.96	0	28
Number of retirement transfers	6,424,114	0.01	0.10	0	6
Number of other transfers	6,424,114	1.97	2.96	0	28
Number of transfers within 1 year of filing	6,424,114	0.67	1.04	0	11
Number of transfers within 2 years of filing	6,424,114	1.18	1.71	0	15
Number of transfers within 3 years of filing	6,424,114	1.57	2.26	0	19
Number of retirement transfers within 1 year of filing	6,424,114	0.01	0.07	0	5
Number of retirement transfers within 2 years of filing	6,424,114	0.01	0.09	0	6
Number of retirement transfers within 3 years of filing	6,424,114	0.01	0.10	0	6
Number of mass transfers	6,424,114	0.62	1.04	0	11
Number of staggered transfers	6,424,114	1.36	2.15	0	23
Number of sections	6,424,114	1.05	0.76	0	30
Sections missing	6,424,114	0.11	0.32	0	1
Bailable crime	6,424,114	0.10	0.30	0	1
Nonbailable crime	6,424,114	0.10	0.31	0	1
Petitioner: State	6,424,114	0.51	0.50	0	1
Petitioner: Government of India	6,424,114	0.00	0.01	0	1
Petitioner: Uttar Pradesh	6,424,114	0.13	0.34	0	1
Petitioner: Female	6,424,114	0.13	0.34	0	1
Petitioner: Gender missing	6,424,114	0.55	0.50	0	1
Respondent: State	6,424,114	0.09	0.29	0	1
Respondent: Government of India	6,424,114	0.00	0.02	0	1
Respondent: Uttar Pradesh	6,424,114	0.03	0.16	0	1
Respondent: Female	6,424,114	0.10	0.29	0	1
Respondent: Gender missing	6,424,114	0.21	0.40	0	1
Civil cases	6,424,114	0.12	0.32	0	1
Criminal cases	6,424,114	0.61	0.49	0	1
Bail cases	6,424,114	0.13	0.34	0	1
Unclassified cases	6,424,114	0.14	0.35	0	1
Cases in Family Courts	6,424,114	0.05	0.23	0	1
Cases in Civil Judge Junior Division Courts	6,424,114	0.10	0.31	0	1
Cases in Civil Judge Senior Division Courts	6,424,114	0.06	0.24	0	1
Cases in Chief Judicial Magistrate Courts	6,424,114	0.53	0.50	0	1
Cases in District and Sessions Courts	6,424,114	0.23	0.42	0	1

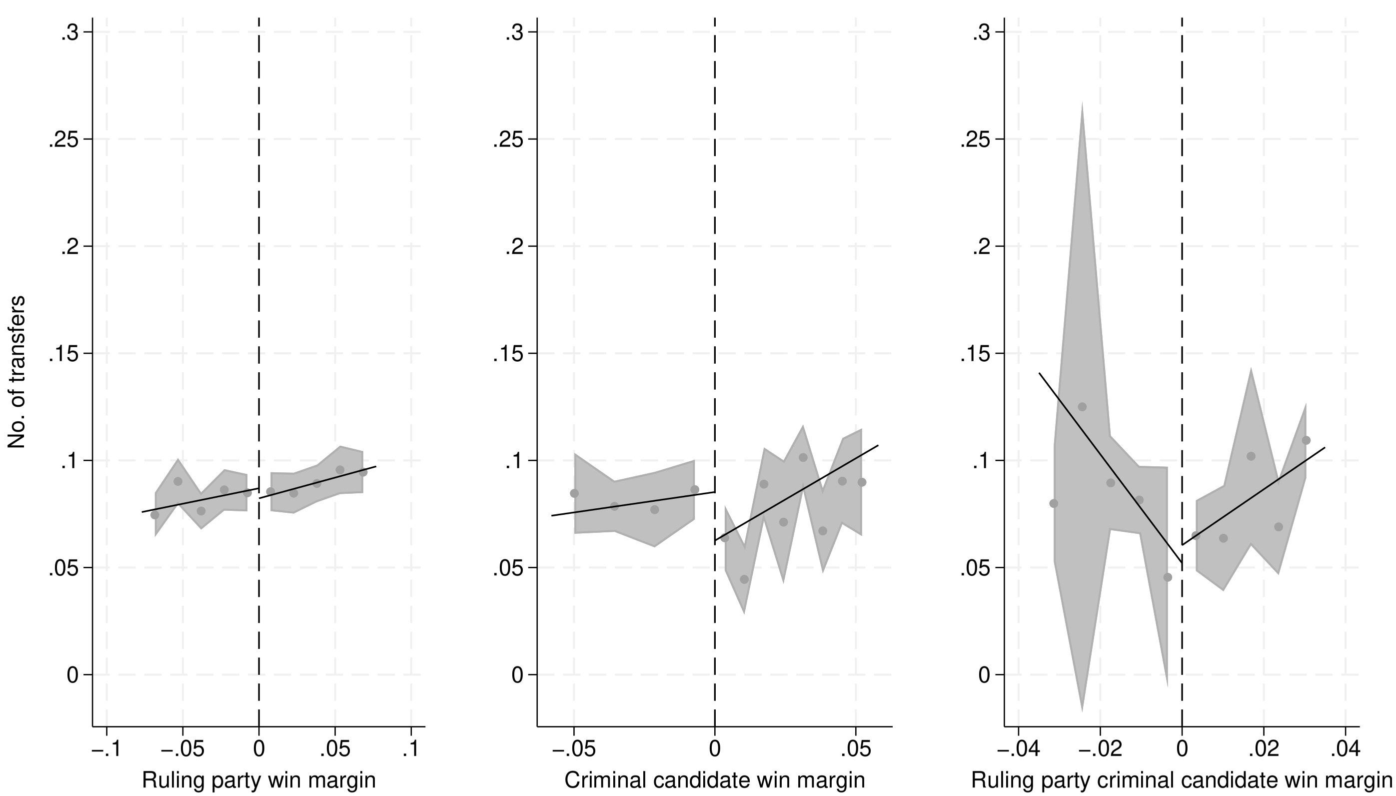
Notes: The data include one observation for each case filed in Uttar Pradesh's lower courts in 2015–2018.

Table B3. Do politician fixed effects explain variation in judge transfers?

Dependent variable	Adjusted R^2	Δ Adjusted R^2	F-stat	Pr > F	N
Transfers	0.188	0.004	1.65	0.000	79610
Retirement transfers	0.063	-0.003	0.64	1.000	79610

Notes: For each dependent variable, column 1 reports the adjusted R^2 from an OLS regression with judge, month–year, and court type fixed effects. Column 2 reports the change in the adjusted R^2 with the addition of politician fixed effects. Columns 3 and 4 report the F-statistic and p-value from tests of the joint significance of politician fixed effects. The last column reports the number of observations in each regression. Politician fixed effects explain very little to no variation in transfers. See text for details.

Figure B2. Regression discontinuity analysis of the causal effects of ruling party politicians, politicians charged with crimes, and ruling party politicians charged with crimes on transfers



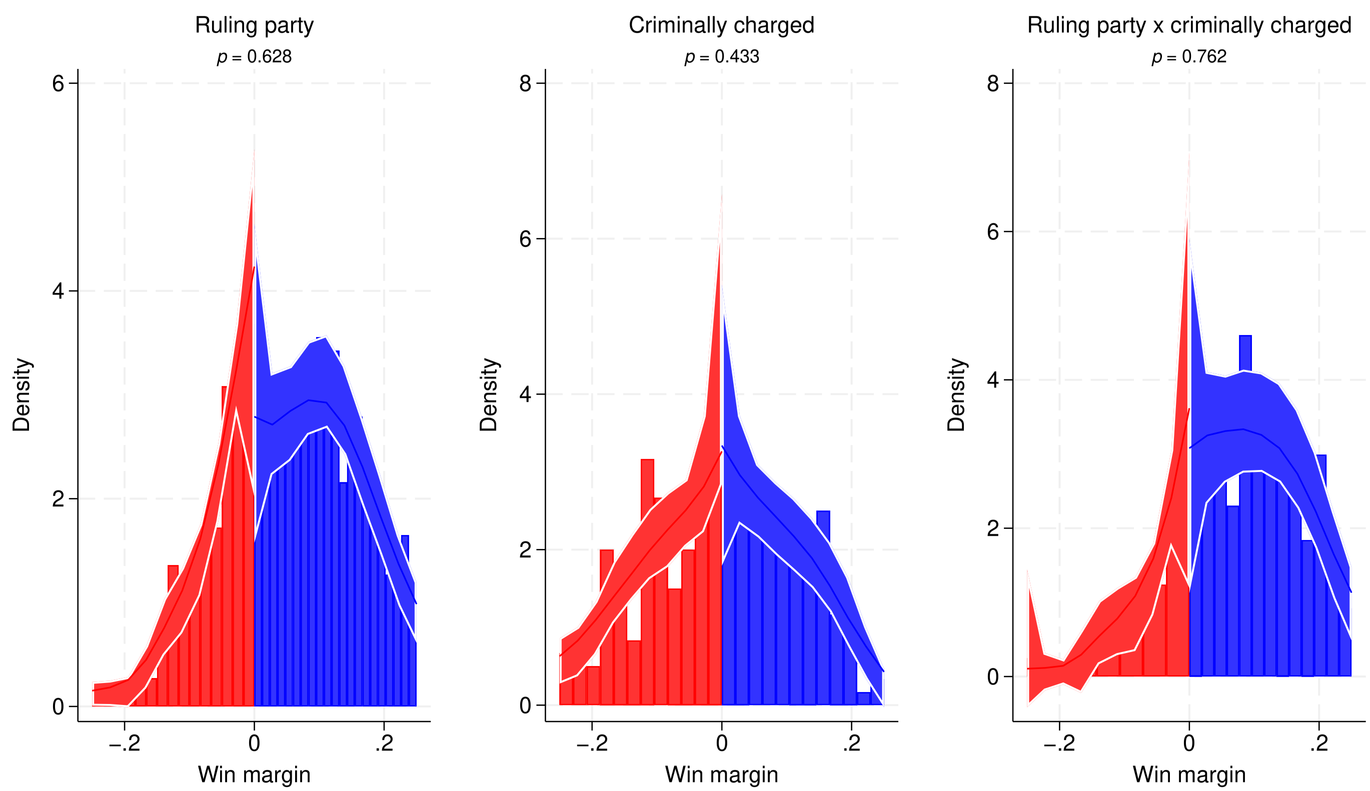
Notes: Each panel plots the number of judge transfers per courtroom-month against the win margin in the courtroom's constituency, signed so that positive values indicate a win by the relevant candidate type (a ruling-party MLA, an MLA charged with crimes, or a ruling-party MLA charged with crimes). Dots are evenly-spaced binned means with shaded 95% confidence intervals. Lines are local-linear fits estimated separately on each side of the cutoff with a triangular kernel, over the same MSE-optimal bandwidth used for the corresponding estimate in Table B4 (its *h* column). The plotted window equals that bandwidth and therefore differs across panels. None of the discontinuities is statistically significant.

Table B4. Regression discontinuity analysis of the causal effects of ruling party politicians, politicians charged with crimes, and ruling party politicians charged with crimes on transfers

	RD est.	CI low	CI high	p	h	Effective N	Clusters
Ruling party	-0.005	-0.035	0.020	0.61	0.077	33232	232
Criminally charged	-0.023	-0.077	0.021	0.26	0.058	11609	97
Ruling x criminal	0.010	-0.051	0.068	0.78	0.035	5364	45

Notes: Local-linear regression discontinuity estimates of the effect of narrowly electing a ruling-party MLA, an MLA charged with crimes, or a ruling-party MLA charged with crimes on judge transfers per courtroom-month. Margins are signed so that positive values indicate the election of the relevant candidate type. Point estimates are conventional local-linear estimates at MSE-optimal bandwidths. Confidence intervals and p-values are robust and bias-corrected. Standard errors are clustered by constituency. Effective N counts courtroom-months within the bandwidth. The last column notes the number of constituency clusters.

Figure B3. Density of the running variables at the cutoff (manipulation tests)



Notes: Each panel plots the local-polynomial density of the running variable on either side of the cutoff with robust 95% confidence intervals, over the histogram of the underlying data. Tests and plots are computed on unique constituency-elections, the level at which the running variable is assigned. p-values are from manipulation tests.

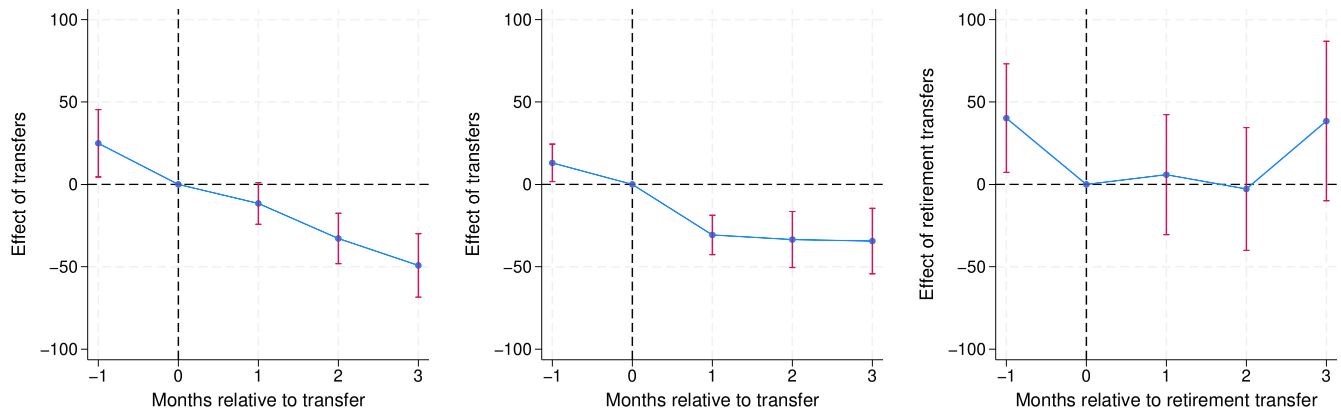
Table B5. Transfers reduce the number of decisions and increase courtroom vacancies (dynamic difference-in-difference estimator)

Dependent variable:	Number of cases decided			Courtroom vacant (0/1)		
Treatment variable:	Any transfers	Any transfers	Retirement transfers	Any transfers	Any transfers	Retirement transfers
Sample:	All courts	District courts	District courts	All courts	District courts	District courts
	1	2	3	4	5	6
Effect_1	-3.402	-5.030***	-3.284	0.201***	0.179***	0.0126
	(2.146)	(0.833)	(2.452)	(0.008)	(0.013)	(0.008)
Effect_2	-5.141***	-3.915***	-9.890***	0.152***	0.152***	0.176***
	(1.983)	(1.167)	(3.074)	(0.008)	(0.012)	(0.035)
Effect_3	-3.189	-0.635	5.024	0.136***	0.132***	0.0783***
	(2.276)	(1.966)	(4.282)	(0.008)	(0.012)	(0.026)
Placebo_1	9.581***	1.601*	2.079	-0.00327***	-0.00387**	0.0146
	(3.331)	(0.934)	(2.240)	(0.001)	(0.002)	(0.010)
Av_tot_eff	-10.47**	-8.409***	-8.082	0.436***	0.406***	0.265***
	(4.515)	(2.658)	(8.068)	(0.019)	(0.029)	(0.054)
Dependent variable mean	44.22	27.88	27.88	0.06	0.04	0.04
Courtroom fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Month-year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

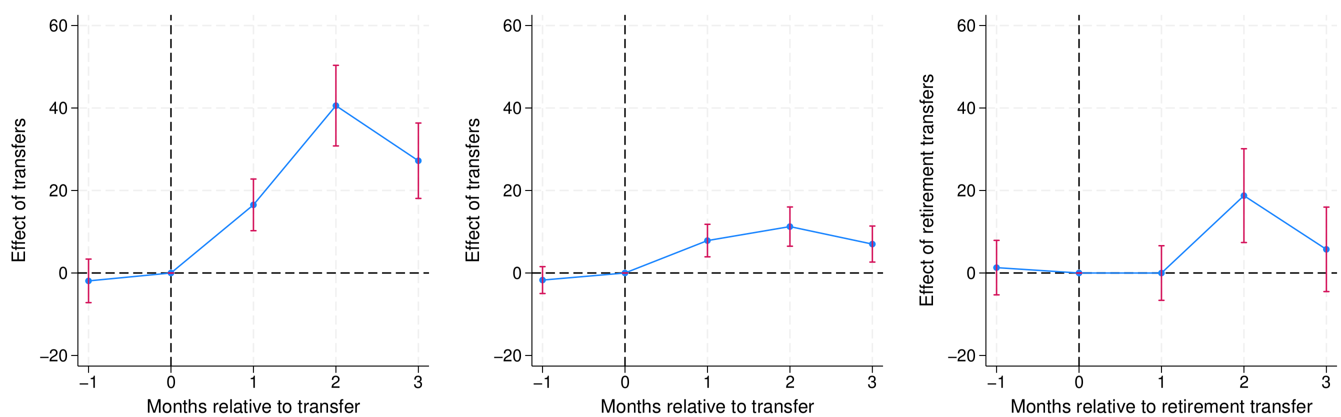
Notes: Standard errors clustered by courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. The analyses in this table employ the dynamic difference-in-difference estimator due to De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille (2024) and correspond to the graphs presented in Figure 2. See text for details.

Figure B4. Transfers reduce the number of hearings and increase the ratio of hearings-to-decisions

DV: Number of hearings



DV: Hearings / (1 + Decisions)



Notes: The dependent variables are the number of hearings (top row) and the number of hearings / (1 + the number of decisions) (bottom row). The data for the plots in the first column cover all courts; the data for the remaining plots cover district courts, from which judges retire. The independent variables are indicators of whether the courtroom experiences a transfer (the first two graphs in each row) and a retirement transfer (the last graphs in each row) and their leads and lags. See text for details.

Table B6. Transfers reduce the number of hearings and increase the ratio of hearings-to-decisions (dynamic difference-in-difference estimator)

Dependent variable:	Number of hearings			Hearings/(1 + Decisions)		
Treatment variable:	Any transfers	Any transfers	Retirement transfers	Any transfers	Any transfers	Retirement transfers
Sample:	All courts	District courts	District courts	All courts	District courts	District courts
	1	2	3	4	5	6
Effect_1	-11.54*	-30.68***	5.894	16.52***	7.860***	-0.0141
	(6.447)	(6.109)	(18.586)	(3.196)	(2.013)	(3.377)
Effect_2	-32.82***	-33.46***	-2.778	40.58***	11.25***	18.76***
	(7.807)	(8.689)	(19.012)	(4.987)	(2.425)	(5.802)
Effect_3	-49.17***	-34.38***	38.45	27.22***	7.012***	5.730
	(9.821)	(10.144)	(24.693)	(4.664)	(2.229)	(5.223)
Placebo_1	24.95**	13.04**	40.23**	-1.911	-1.719	1.298
	(10.436)	(5.814)	(16.812)	(2.692)	(1.662)	(3.371)
Av_tot_eff	-82.92***	-86.39***	41.20	74.75***	22.91***	24.26**
	(17.903)	(18.668)	(51.753)	(9.349)	(4.254)	(12.067)
Dependent variable mean	626.78	476.28	476.28	60.24	35.28	35.28
Courtroom fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Month-year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Notes: Standard errors clustered by courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. The analyses in this table employ the dynamic difference-in-difference estimator due to De Chaisemartin and d'Haultfoeuille (2024) and correspond to the graphs presented in Figure B4. See text for details.

Table B7. Transfers reduce the number of decisions and increase courtroom vacancies (two-way fixed effects estimator)

Dependent variable:	Number of cases decided			Courtroom vacant(0/1)		
Treatment variable:	Any transfers	Any transfers	Retirement transfers	Any transfers	Any transfers	Retirement transfers
Sample:	All courts	District courts	District courts	All courts	District courts	District courts
	1	2	3	4	5	6
Effect_1	-10.46***	-4.076***	-18.76***	0.0484***	0.0486***	0.132***
	(1.552)	(0.775)	(2.957)	(0.00312)	(0.00467)	(0.0324)
Effect_2	-2.142	-1.699**	-2.613	0.0392***	0.0366***	0.0503**
	(1.819)	(0.780)	(3.942)	(0.00301)	(0.00434)	(0.0225)
Effect_3	-5.838***	-2.920***	-2.648	0.0310***	0.0233***	0.0271
	(1.105)	(0.705)	(4.130)	(0.00300)	(0.00408)	(0.0183)
Placebo_1	-5.175***	-1.716***	-8.606***	-0.0373***	-0.0290***	-0.0194***
	(1.423)	(0.612)	(3.033)	(0.00257)	(0.00337)	(0.00740)
Observations	87070	34928	34928	87070	34928	34928
Adjusted R-squared	0.37	0.51	0.51	0.33	0.22	0.21
Dependent variable mean	45.79	28.90	28.90	0.06	0.04	0.04
Courtroom fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Month-year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Notes: Standard errors clustered by courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

Table B8. Transfers reduce the number of hearings and increase the ratio of hearings-to-decisions (two-way fixed effects estimator)

Dependent variable:	Number of hearings		Number of hearings/(1+Number of decisions)	
Treatment variable:	Any transfers	Retirement transfers	Any transfers	Retirement transfers
	1	2	3	4
Effect_1	-48.43***	-113.5***	28.89***	46.55***
	(6.526)	(24.93)	(2.460)	(15.27)
Effect_2	-35.10***	-65.75***	17.82***	39.77***
	(6.930)	(24.77)	(2.135)	(15.16)
Effect_3	-50.04***	-57.60**	7.729***	15.74**
	(6.196)	(28.49)	(1.954)	(6.354)
Placebo_1	-28.50***	-103.4***	8.156***	-2.949
	(6.580)	(24.88)	(2.067)	(3.013)
Observations	82345	82345	82345	82345
Adjusted R-squared	0.69	0.69	0.23	0.23
Dependent variable mean	658.02	658.02	62.41	62.41
Courtroom fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Month-year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

Notes: Standard errors clustered by courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

Table B9. Full results for Table 1, Panel A with all covariates

	Case decided by end-2021 (0/1)				Judge vacancy (0/1)	No. of vacant spells	No. of hearings
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Panel A:							
Number of transfers	-0.0976***	-0.0875***	-0.0926***	-0.0929***	0.0117***	0.0153***	3.382***
	(0.00210)	(0.00223)	(0.00245)	(0.00226)	(0.00112)	(0.00146)	(0.0784)
Number of sections		-0.0155***	-0.00843***	-0.00912***	0.000168	0.0000209	0.299***
		(0.00220)	(0.00150)	(0.00157)	(0.000987)	(0.00131)	(0.0454)
Sections missing		-0.0431***	-0.0268***	-0.0279***	0.0124***	0.0136**	1.865***
		(0.00584)	(0.00531)	(0.00531)	(0.00456)	(0.00571)	(0.170)
Bailable crime		-0.0783***	-0.0392***	-0.0433***	0.00284	0.00184	0.562***
		(0.00719)	(0.00529)	(0.00544)	(0.00377)	(0.00528)	(0.144)
Nonbailable crime		-0.0717***	-0.0457***	-0.0458***	0.00937***	0.0104**	1.883***
		(0.00581)	(0.00524)	(0.00533)	(0.00350)	(0.00491)	(0.182)
Petitioner: State		-0.0194**	-0.0102	-0.0192***	-0.0120***	-0.0110**	0.742***
		(0.00817)	(0.00620)	(0.00571)	(0.00401)	(0.00478)	(0.243)
Petitioner: Government of India		-0.0611	-0.0857**	-0.0577**	0.0185	0.0192	-0.172
		(0.0507)	(0.0356)	(0.0252)	(0.0124)	(0.0148)	(0.685)
Petitioner: Uttar Pradesh		-0.0159*	-0.0280**	-0.0237**	-0.000271	-0.00733	1.167***
		(0.00926)	(0.0119)	(0.0103)	(0.00593)	(0.00816)	(0.417)
Petitioner: Female		0.0249***	0.0114***	0.00672***	0.00220**	0.00252*	0.376***
		(0.00240)	(0.00155)	(0.00139)	(0.00103)	(0.00146)	(0.0541)
Petitioner: Gender missing		0.00366	-0.00782**	-0.00882**	0.00132	0.00400	-0.426***
		(0.00551)	(0.00398)	(0.00381)	(0.00293)	(0.00345)	(0.151)
Respondent: State		0.0279***	-0.0136**	0.000586	-0.00165	0.000926	-7.719***
		(0.00767)	(0.00666)	(0.00729)	(0.00519)	(0.00732)	(0.921)
Respondent: Government of India		-0.190***	-0.206***	-0.126**	-0.00847	0.0233	3.333
		(0.0726)	(0.0666)	(0.0533)	(0.0314)	(0.0684)	(3.365)
Respondent: Uttar Pradesh		0.0103	-0.0160	-0.00362	0.0104	0.0125	1.122
		(0.0113)	(0.0115)	(0.0115)	(0.0106)	(0.0146)	(1.030)
Respondent: Female		0.00832***	0.00165	0.00235	0.00167*	0.00177	-0.255***
		(0.00227)	(0.00151)	(0.00150)	(0.00101)	(0.00141)	(0.0643)
Respondent: Gender missing		0.00947***	0.00568***	0.00574***	0.00105	0.00101	-0.482***
		(0.00217)	(0.00147)	(0.00138)	(0.00101)	(0.00125)	(0.0525)
Constant	0.977***	1.178***	1.134***	1.095***	0.0657***	0.0737***	6.848***
	(0.00316)	(0.0185)	(0.0202)	(0.0182)	(0.00732)	(0.00969)	(0.471)
Observations	6424114	6424114	6423811	6423310	6423310	6423310	6388360
Adjusted R-squared	0.49	0.54	0.63	0.65	0.42	0.43	0.69
Dependent variable mean	0.78	0.78	0.78	0.78	0.08	0.09	12.05
Act fixed effects		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Case type fixed effects		✓	✓				
Courtroom fixed effects			✓				
Case type X courtroom fixed effects				✓	✓	✓	✓
Filing month-year fixed effects			✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Notes: Standard errors clustered by courtroom for regressions in columns 1–3; standard errors are clustered by case type X courtroom for the regressions in columns 4–7. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

Table B10. Full results for Table 1, Panel B with all covariates

	Case decided by end-2021 (0/1)				Judge vacancy (0/1)	No. of vacant spells	No. of hearings
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Panel B:							
Number of retirement transfers	0.0712***	0.0276	-0.0430**	-0.0473***	0.0945***	0.142***	4.145***
	(0.0210)	(0.0193)	(0.0195)	(0.0147)	(0.0192)	(0.0306)	(0.401)
Number of other transfers	-0.0979***	-0.0878***	-0.0927***	-0.0931***	0.0115***	0.0149***	3.380***
	(0.00212)	(0.00225)	(0.00247)	(0.00228)	(0.00112)	(0.00144)	(0.0787)
Number of sections		-0.0154***	-0.00842***	-0.00911***	0.000196	0.0000638	0.299***
		(0.00220)	(0.00150)	(0.00157)	(0.000986)	(0.00131)	(0.0454)
Sections missing		-0.0423***	-0.0266***	-0.0278***	0.0126***	0.0139**	1.867***
		(0.00584)	(0.00531)	(0.00530)	(0.00456)	(0.00570)	(0.170)
Bailable crime		-0.0780***	-0.0393***	-0.0434***	0.00278	0.00175	0.561***
		(0.00720)	(0.00529)	(0.00543)	(0.00377)	(0.00528)	(0.144)
Nonbailable crime		-0.0716***	-0.0457***	-0.0459***	0.00926***	0.0102**	1.882***
		(0.00579)	(0.00524)	(0.00532)	(0.00349)	(0.00490)	(0.182)
Petitioner: State		-0.0171**	-0.00973	-0.0190***	-0.0117***	-0.0105**	0.746***
		(0.00814)	(0.00617)	(0.00571)	(0.00400)	(0.00477)	(0.242)
Petitioner: Government of India		-0.0638	-0.0864**	-0.0584**	0.0171	0.0171	-0.185
		(0.0490)	(0.0352)	(0.0250)	(0.0123)	(0.0147)	(0.683)
Petitioner: Uttar Pradesh		-0.0159*	-0.0280**	-0.0237**	-0.000284	-0.00735	1.167***
		(0.00925)	(0.0119)	(0.0103)	(0.00592)	(0.00814)	(0.417)
Petitioner: Female		0.0241***	0.0113***	0.00667***	0.00210**	0.00237	0.375***
		(0.00239)	(0.00155)	(0.00139)	(0.00102)	(0.00145)	(0.0540)
Petitioner: Gender missing		0.00204	-0.00836**	-0.00918**	0.000660	0.00299	-0.433***
		(0.00551)	(0.00395)	(0.00380)	(0.00288)	(0.00336)	(0.151)
Respondent: State		0.0271***	-0.0134**	0.000299	-0.00217	0.000129	-7.724***
		(0.00763)	(0.00664)	(0.00731)	(0.00516)	(0.00727)	(0.921)
Respondent: Government of India		-0.201***	-0.210***	-0.127**	-0.0112	0.0191	3.309
		(0.0763)	(0.0682)	(0.0526)	(0.0328)	(0.0704)	(3.361)
Respondent: Uttar Pradesh		0.00966	-0.0153	-0.00377	0.0101	0.0121	1.120
		(0.0112)	(0.0116)	(0.0116)	(0.0105)	(0.0142)	(1.030)
Respondent: Female		0.00789***	0.00175	0.00240	0.00176*	0.00191	-0.254***
		(0.00224)	(0.00152)	(0.00150)	(0.00100)	(0.00140)	(0.0643)
Respondent: Gender missing		0.00959***	0.00567***	0.00571***	0.000999	0.000931	-0.483***
		(0.00218)	(0.00147)	(0.00138)	(0.00101)	(0.00125)	(0.0524)
Constant	0.976***	1.178***	1.135***	1.097***	0.0686***	0.0780***	6.875***
	(0.00315)	(0.0186)	(0.0204)	(0.0183)	(0.00742)	(0.00981)	(0.473)
Observations	6424114	6424114	6423811	6423310	6423310	6423310	6388360
Adjusted R-squared	0.49	0.54	0.63	0.65	0.42	0.43	0.69
Dependent variable mean	0.78	0.78	0.78	0.78	0.08	0.09	12.05
Act fixed effects		✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Case type fixed effects		✓	✓				
Courtroom fixed effects			✓				
Case type X courtroom fixed effects				✓	✓	✓	✓
Filing month-year fixed effects			✓	✓	✓	✓	✓

Notes: Standard errors clustered by courtroom for regressions in columns 1–3; standard errors are clustered by case type X courtroom for the regressions in columns 4–7. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

Table B11. Robustness tests: Transfers reduce the chances of a case being decided

Transfers specified as:	Count 1	Dummy 2	Log 3	Winsorized 4
Panel A:				
Number of transfers	-0.0929***	-0.347***	-0.325***	-0.109***
	(0.00304)	(0.00897)	(0.00638)	(0.00228)
Observations	6423310	6423310	6423310	6423310
Adjusted R-squared	0.65	0.49	0.63	0.66
Panel B:				
Number of retirement transfers	-0.0473***	-0.0167	-0.00472	-0.0268**
	(0.0175)	(0.0244)	(0.0248)	(0.0136)
Number of other transfers	-0.0931***	-0.347***	-0.326***	-0.110***
	(0.00305)	(0.00899)	(0.00641)	(0.00229)
Observations	6423310	6423310	6423310	6423310
Adjusted R-squared	0.65	0.49	0.63	0.66
Mean dependent variable	0.78	0.78	0.78	0.78
Act fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Case type X courtroom fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Filing month-year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓

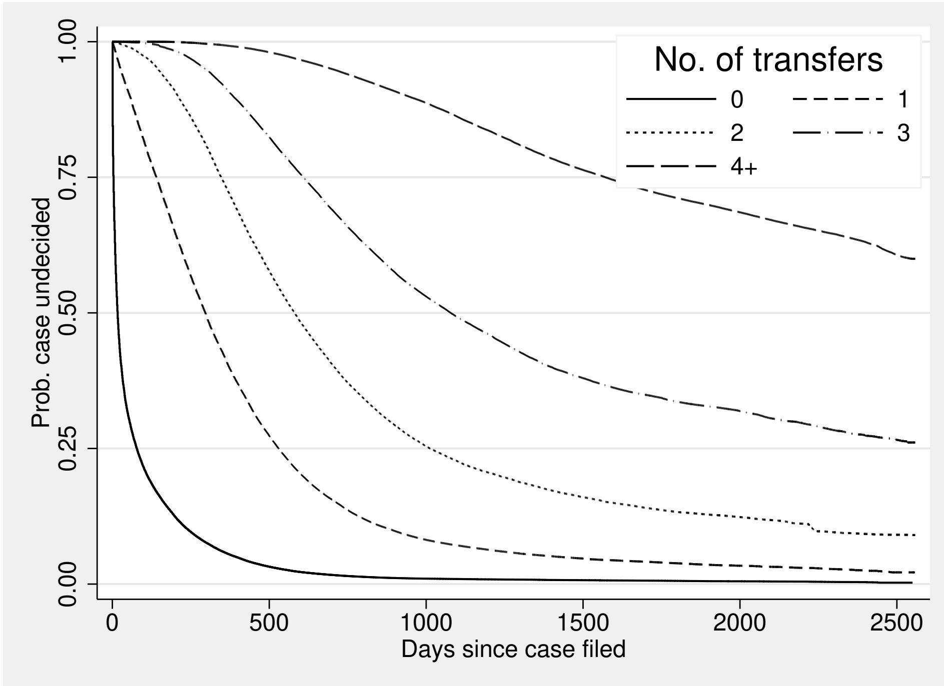
Notes: The dependent variable is an indicator for whether a case was decided; the independent variable is transfers, specified as a count (column 1; this is the same specification as in Table 1 but with standard errors clustered at the court rather than by case type X courtroom), a dummy variable (column 2), logged (column 3) and winsorized (column 4). Case-specific controls are the number of sections to which cases refer (with a missing-data indicator), indicators for bailable and nonbailable crimes, and indicators for the parties' gender (with missing-data indicators) and whether they are the government. Standard errors in columns 2–4 are clustered by case type X courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

Table B12. Fixed-horizon duration models: Transfers reduce the chances of a case being decided, particularly in the early years

Case decided (0/1) and Number of transfers measured:	1 year since filing 1	2 years since filing 2	3 years since filing 3
Panel A:			
Number of transfers	-0.192***	-0.157***	-0.128***
	(0.00381)	(0.00278)	(0.00224)
Observations	6423310	6423310	6423310
Adjusted R-squared	0.52	0.58	0.64
Panel B:			
Number of retirement transfers	-0.212***	-0.160***	-0.110***
	(0.0205)	(0.0155)	(0.0156)
Number of other transfers	-0.192***	-0.157***	-0.129***
	(0.00384)	(0.00279)	(0.00225)
Observations	6423310	6423310	6423310
Adjusted R-squared	0.52	0.58	0.64
Dependent variable mean	0.59	0.69	0.74
Case-specific controls	✓	✓	✓
Act fixed effects	✓	✓	✓
Case type X courtroom fixed effects	✓	✓	✓
Filing month-year fixed effects	✓	✓	✓

Notes: The dependent variable is an indicator for whether a case was decided; the independent variable is transfers. Case-specific controls are the number of sections to which cases refer (with a missing-data indicator), indicators for bailable and nonbailable crimes, and indicators for the parties' gender (with missing-data indicators) and whether they are the government. Standard errors are clustered by case type X courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

Figure B5. Kaplan–Meier survival curves: Time to decision by the number of transfers



Notes: Kaplan-Meier estimates of the probability that a case remains undecided, by the total number of transfers the case experienced. Because transfers accumulate with time pending, the figure is descriptive. See text for details.

Table B13. Robustness test: Transfers increase the years to decision for decided cases

	Time to decision (years)			
	1	2	3	4
Panel A:				
transfer_out	0.488***	0.448***	0.454***	0.453***
	(0.0109)	(0.00995)	(0.00882)	(0.00770)
Observations	5032089	5032089	5031969	5031452
Adjusted R-squared	0.64	0.68	0.76	0.77
Panel B:				
Retirement transfer	0.620***	0.526***	0.518***	0.531***
	(0.0807)	(0.0672)	(0.0461)	(0.0320)
transfer_outnor	0.487***	0.448***	0.453***	0.453***
	(0.0109)	(0.0100)	(0.00889)	(0.00776)
Observations	5032089	5032089	5031969	5031452
Adjusted R-squared	0.64	0.68	0.76	0.77
Dependent variable mean	0.71	0.71	0.71	0.71
Case-specific controls		✓	✓	✓
Act fixed effects		✓	✓	✓
Case type fixed effects		✓	✓	
Courtroom fixed effects			✓	
Case type X courtroom fixed effects				✓
Filing month-year fixed effects			✓	✓

Notes: The dependent variable is the years to decision; the independent variable is the number of transfers. Case-specific controls are the number of sections to which cases refer (with a missing-data indicator), indicators for bailable and nonbailable crimes, and indicators for the parties' gender (with missing-data indicators) and whether they are the government. Standard errors clustered by courtroom for regressions in columns 1–3; standard errors are clustered by case type X courtroom for the regressions in column 4. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

Table B14. Full results for Table 2, Panel A with all covariates

	Case decided (0/1)								
Sample:	Civil cases	Criminal cases	Bail cases	Unclassified cases	Civil judge Junior div	Civil judge Senior div	Chief Judicial Magistrate	District and Sessions courts	Family courts
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
Panel A:									
Number of transfers	-0.0836***	-0.0972***	-0.0149***	-0.0669***	-0.113***	-0.0889***	-0.0991***	-0.0689***	-0.0604***
	(0.00232)	(0.00309)	(0.00307)	(0.00381)	(0.00625)	(0.00330)	(0.00388)	(0.00192)	(0.00469)
Number of sections	0.00627	-0.0108***	-0.0000304	-0.00100	-0.000294	-0.00233	-0.0104***	-0.00334**	-0.00511*
	(0.00934)	(0.00223)	(0.0000280)	(0.00379)	(0.00490)	(0.00241)	(0.00212)	(0.00154)	(0.00268)
Sections missing	-0.0107	-0.0211***	-0.000354*	-0.0315***	-0.0238	-0.00936	-0.0267***	-0.0191***	-0.0244***
	(0.0166)	(0.00665)	(0.000193)	(0.00995)	(0.0161)	(0.00926)	(0.00693)	(0.00548)	(0.00835)
Bailable crime		-0.0451***	-0.000400**		-0.0399***	-0.00289	-0.0424***	-0.0184***	-0.0194
		(0.00628)	(0.000157)		(0.0126)	(0.0128)	(0.00712)	(0.00500)	(0.0976)
Nonbailable crime		-0.0615***	-0.000136		-0.0543***	0.00959	-0.0577***	-0.0135***	0.00587
		(0.00679)	(0.000104)		(0.0148)	(0.00971)	(0.00774)	(0.00425)	(0.00774)
Petitioner: State	0.00597	-0.0201***	0.00199***	0.0617***	-0.0507***	-0.0224**	-0.0156*	-0.129***	
	(0.0126)	(0.00702)	(0.000741)	(0.0196)	(0.0139)	(0.00928)	(0.00897)	(0.0118)	
Petitioner: Government of India	-0.0208	-0.0473	-0.00107	-0.260***	0.0581	-0.0851**	-0.0801***	0.106***	
	(0.0237)	(0.0318)	(0.00118)	(0.0639)	(0.0567)	(0.0350)	(0.0308)	(0.0268)	
Petitioner: Uttar Pradesh	0.00362	-0.0236**	-0.00166**	0.00913	0.00670	0.0178	-0.0261**	-0.0323*	
	(0.0182)	(0.0114)	(0.000754)	(0.0275)	(0.0173)	(0.0131)	(0.0126)	(0.0188)	
Petitioner: Female	0.00788***	0.00476*	-0.000340**	0.0147***	0.00891***	0.0114***	0.00654**	0.0126***	-0.00277*
	(0.00158)	(0.00262)	(0.000152)	(0.00275)	(0.00188)	(0.00223)	(0.00282)	(0.00207)	(0.00148)
Petitioner: Gender missing	0.000833	-0.0145**	0.000125*	-0.0313***	0.00108	0.000591	-0.0140*	-0.0262***	-0.000542
	(0.00610)	(0.00652)	(0.0000713)	(0.0113)	(0.00290)	(0.00369)	(0.00798)	(0.00586)	(0.00185)
Respondent: State	0.00519	0.00229	0.00260***	-0.0377	0.00440	-0.00142	0.00234	-0.0266***	
	(0.00851)	(0.0118)	(0.000836)	(0.0240)	(0.0112)	(0.00766)	(0.00937)	(0.0103)	
Respondent: Government of India	-0.0346	0.0841	0.00139	-0.265***	0.0763**	-0.0367*	0.00198	-0.141**	
	(0.0387)	(0.0683)	(0.00108)	(0.0361)	(0.0363)	(0.0208)	(0.0508)	(0.0608)	
Respondent: Uttar Pradesh	-0.0420***	-0.0143	-0.000503	-0.0173	-0.0328**	-0.0262***	-0.0571***	0.00388	
	(0.0134)	(0.0141)	(0.000308)	(0.0282)	(0.0137)	(0.00966)	(0.0189)	(0.0132)	
Respondent: Female	0.00742***	-0.000790	0.000229	0.00394	0.00229	0.00312*	-0.00156	0.00165	0.00539***
	(0.00144)	(0.00268)	(0.000206)	(0.00241)	(0.00186)	(0.00169)	(0.00304)	(0.00215)	(0.00186)
Respondent: Gender missing	0.00485	0.00861***	0.0000787	0.00115	0.00412*	0.00267	0.00935***	-0.00609**	0.00385**
	(0.00435)	(0.00177)	(0.000140)	(0.00205)	(0.00217)	(0.00212)	(0.00189)	(0.00260)	(0.00181)
Constant	1.034***	1.072***	1.012***	1.062***	0.940***	1.032***	1.065***	1.260***	1.135***
	(0.0175)	(0.0266)	(0.00675)	(0.0237)	(0.0725)	(0.0744)	(0.0244)	(0.0176)	(0.103)
Observations	768281	3912472	833863	908694	669153	384950	3411833	1492512	352337
Adjusted R-squared	0.57	0.67	0.16	0.54	0.61	0.66	0.69	0.65	0.28
Mean dependent variable	0.65	0.74	1.00	0.88	0.63	0.79	0.77	0.86	0.93

Notes: The independent variables are defined as transfers until end-2021. All regressions control for act fixed effects, case type X courtroom fixed effects, and filing month-year fixed effects. Judges retire from the District and Sessions courts and Family courts. Standard errors clustered by case type X courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

Table B15. Full results for Table 2, Panel B with all covariates

	Case decided (0/1)								
Sample:	Civil cases	Criminal cases	Bail cases	Unclassified cases	Civil judge Junior div	Civil judge Senior div	Chief Judicial Magistrate	District and Sessions courts	Family courts
	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9
Panel B:									
Retirement transfer	-0.0472**	-0.100***	-0.00925	-0.0127				-0.0207	-0.00781
	(0.0239)	(0.0188)	(0.00801)	(0.0312)				(0.0185)	(0.0132)
transfer_outnor	-0.0843***	-0.0976***	-0.0150***	-0.0674***	-0.115***	-0.0916***	-0.0989***	-0.0694***	-0.0606***
	(0.00237)	(0.00310)	(0.00312)	(0.00384)	(0.00610)	(0.00337)	(0.00389)	(0.00198)	(0.00475)
sections_count	0.00446	-0.00957***	-0.0000211	0.00149	-0.00146	-0.000997	-0.00885***	-0.00239*	-0.00402**
	(0.00607)	(0.00188)	(0.0000234)	(0.00345)	(0.00382)	(0.00194)	(0.00182)	(0.00140)	(0.00190)
sections_missing	-0.0156	-0.0108*	-0.000331*	-0.0286***	-0.0227	-0.00412	-0.0144**	-0.0152***	-0.0200**
	(0.0149)	(0.00603)	(0.000186)	(0.00863)	(0.0149)	(0.00778)	(0.00631)	(0.00511)	(0.00796)
bailableipc		-0.0466***	-0.000409**		-0.0400***	-0.00477	-0.0435***	-0.0185***	-0.0196
		(0.00626)	(0.000159)		(0.0126)	(0.0124)	(0.00715)	(0.00510)	(0.0974)
nonbailableipc		-0.0638***	-0.000147		-0.0561***	0.00961	-0.0582***	-0.0120***	0.00640
		(0.00677)	(0.000106)		(0.0147)	(0.00950)	(0.00776)	(0.00422)	(0.00731)
state_petitioner_all	0.00672	-0.0195***	0.00199***	0.0618***	-0.0509***	-0.0236***	-0.0145	-0.126***	
	(0.0125)	(0.00707)	(0.000740)	(0.0197)	(0.0139)	(0.00900)	(0.00900)	(0.0119)	
state_petitioner_goi	-0.0214	-0.0447	-0.00107	-0.260***	0.0617	-0.0651*	-0.0801***	0.101***	
	(0.0235)	(0.0321)	(0.00117)	(0.0626)	(0.0571)	(0.0383)	(0.0309)	(0.0268)	
state_petitioner_up	0.00309	-0.0234**	-0.00163**	0.00799	0.00978	0.0243**	-0.0264**	-0.0321*	
	(0.0185)	(0.0114)	(0.000779)	(0.0277)	(0.0179)	(0.0124)	(0.0125)	(0.0192)	
female_petitioner	0.00780***	0.00458*	-0.000330**	0.0143***	0.00932***	0.0102***	0.00628**	0.0125***	-0.00301**
	(0.00159)	(0.00263)	(0.000154)	(0.00279)	(0.00188)	(0.00217)	(0.00282)	(0.00209)	(0.00146)
female_petitioner_missing	0.000117	-0.0146**	0.000118	-0.0314***	0.000912	0.000409	-0.0141*	-0.0269***	-0.000594
	(0.00585)	(0.00658)	(0.0000715)	(0.0112)	(0.00288)	(0.00350)	(0.00802)	(0.00580)	(0.00182)
state_respondent_all	0.00511	0.0111	0.00260***	-0.0395	0.00459	-0.00156	0.00298	-0.0306***	
	(0.00848)	(0.0119)	(0.000840)	(0.0254)	(0.0111)	(0.00767)	(0.00959)	(0.0102)	
state_respondent_goi	-0.0366	0.0787	0.00144	-0.263***	0.0726**	-0.0360*	0.000742	-0.138**	
	(0.0358)	(0.0681)	(0.00107)	(0.0367)	(0.0367)	(0.0210)	(0.0511)	(0.0591)	
state_respondent_up	-0.0441***	-0.0152	-0.000465	-0.0147	-0.0340**	-0.0244**	-0.0586***	0.00382	
	(0.0141)	(0.0144)	(0.000298)	(0.0289)	(0.0136)	(0.00967)	(0.0189)	(0.0130)	
female_defendant	0.00744***	-0.000957	0.000225	0.00392	0.00236	0.00290*	-0.00166	0.00149	0.00531***
	(0.00144)	(0.00267)	(0.000206)	(0.00241)	(0.00183)	(0.00164)	(0.00302)	(0.00219)	(0.00183)
female_defendant_missing	0.00483	0.00883***	0.0000689	0.00113	0.00483**	0.00156	0.00946***	-0.00599**	0.00388**
	(0.00433)	(0.00179)	(0.000141)	(0.00207)	(0.00217)	(0.00201)	(0.00189)	(0.00263)	(0.00178)
Constant	1.043***	1.063***	1.012***	1.063***	0.947***	1.047***	1.055***	1.262***	1.147***
	(0.0150)	(0.0265)	(0.00679)	(0.0244)	(0.0733)	(0.0814)	(0.0243)	(0.0177)	(0.114)
Observations	768088	3911003	833862	908225	672880	387050	3411740	1477136	359166
Adjusted *R*-squared	0.57	0.67	0.16	0.54	0.61	0.67	0.69	0.65	0.28
Mean dependent variable	0.65	0.74	1.00	0.88	0.63	0.77	0.77	0.86	0.93

Notes: The independent variables are defined as transfers until end-2021. All regressions control for act fixed effects, case type X courtroom fixed effects, and filing month-year fixed effects. Judges retire from the District and Sessions courts and Family courts. Standard errors clustered by case type X courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

Table B16. Full results for Table 3 with all covariates

	Case decided (0/1)	Judge vacancy (0/1)	No. of vacant spells	No. of hearings	Case decided (0/1)	
	1	2	3	4	5	6
No. until scheduled transfers by Dec. 31, 2021	-0.113***	0.00666*	0.00792*	3.962***		
	(0.00656)	(0.00373)	(0.00438)	(0.204)		
No. until non-scheduled transfers by Dec. 31, 2021	-0.0845***	0.0137***	0.0183***	3.144***		
	(0.00271)	(0.00215)	(0.00254)	(0.0954)		
transfer_out					-0.0935***	
					(0.00227)	
transfer_outbail					0.0864***	
					(0.00397)	
Retirement transfer						-0.0446***
						(0.0153)
retirementbail						-0.0176
						(0.0196)
transfer_outnor						-0.0937***
						(0.00228)
transfer_outnorbail						0.0878***
						(0.00407)
sections_count	-0.00754***	0.000204	0.000105	0.244***	-0.00764***	-0.00762***
	(0.00134)	(0.000815)	(0.00107)	(0.0381)	(0.00133)	(0.00133)
sections_missing	-0.0189***	0.0122***	0.0135**	1.545***	-0.0190***	-0.0189***
	(0.00494)	(0.00448)	(0.00561)	(0.160)	(0.00490)	(0.00489)
bailableipc	-0.0445***	0.00304	0.00195	0.632***	-0.0442***	-0.0442***
	(0.00545)	(0.00378)	(0.00529)	(0.146)	(0.00543)	(0.00542)
nonbailableipc	-0.0473***	0.00964***	0.0107**	1.963***	-0.0473***	-0.0474***
	(0.00541)	(0.00351)	(0.00491)	(0.189)	(0.00534)	(0.00534)
state_petitioner_all	-0.0188***	-0.0121***	-0.0111**	0.739***	-0.0189***	-0.0187***
	(0.00577)	(0.00401)	(0.00478)	(0.243)	(0.00574)	(0.00573)
state_petitioner_goi	-0.0549**	0.0192	0.0202	-0.272	-0.0547**	-0.0555**
	(0.0238)	(0.0124)	(0.0147)	(0.708)	(0.0246)	(0.0244)
state_petitioner_up	-0.0228**	-0.0000413	-0.00702	1.142***	-0.0237**	-0.0237**
	(0.0104)	(0.00595)	(0.00817)	(0.424)	(0.0103)	(0.0103)
female_petitioner	0.00650***	0.00225**	0.00257*	0.384***	0.00661***	0.00656***
	(0.00139)	(0.00103)	(0.00146)	(0.0540)	(0.00140)	(0.00140)
female_petitioner_missing	-0.00991**	0.00110	0.00368	-0.399***	-0.00875**	-0.00912**
	(0.00392)	(0.00295)	(0.00346)	(0.149)	(0.00383)	(0.00382)
state_respondent_all	0.00484	-0.00264	-0.000439	-7.859***	0.00414	0.00389
	(0.00750)	(0.00519)	(0.00731)	(0.938)	(0.00745)	(0.00747)
state_respondent_goi	-0.136**	-0.00866	0.0229	3.616	-0.129**	-0.131**
	(0.0549)	(0.0318)	(0.0691)	(3.314)	(0.0531)	(0.0524)
state_respondent_up	-0.00281	0.0110	0.0132	1.091	-0.00322	-0.00366
	(0.0121)	(0.0107)	(0.0147)	(1.044)	(0.0120)	(0.0121)
female_defendant	0.00208	0.00160	0.00169	-0.248***	0.00219	0.00225
	(0.00152)	(0.00101)	(0.00141)	(0.0649)	(0.00150)	(0.00150)
female_defendant_missing	0.00567***	0.000947	0.000878	-0.479***	0.00590***	0.00587***
	(0.00139)	(0.00101)	(0.00125)	(0.0525)	(0.00139)	(0.00139)
Constant	1.091***	0.0676***	0.0760***	6.977***	1.087***	1.089***
	(0.0184)	(0.00730)	(0.00970)	(0.452)	(0.0181)	(0.0183)
Observations	6421178	6421178	6421178	6386226	6421178	6421178
Adjusted R-squared	0.65	0.42	0.43	0.69	0.65	0.65
Mean dependent variable	0.78	0.08	0.09	12.05	0.78	0.78

Notes: The independent variables are defined as transfers until end-2021. All regressions control for act fixed effects, case type X courtroom fixed effects, and filing month-year fixed effects. Standard errors clustered by case type X courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.

Table B17. External validity: Transfers are associated with an increased time to decision in all states

	Time to decision (years)			
	1	2	3	4
At least one transfer	1.135*** (0.0407)	1.070*** (0.0385)	0.995*** (0.0337)	
At least one transfer in Uttar Pradesh				0.946*** (0.00517)
At least one transfer in Maharashtra				0.969*** (0.00574)
At least one transfer in Bihar				0.596*** (0.00233)
At least one transfer in West Bengal				1.097*** (0.00532)
At least one transfer in Madhya Pradesh				1.128*** (0.00633)
At least one transfer in Tamil Nadu				1.088*** (0.00941)
At least one transfer in Rajasthan				1.299*** (0.0101)
At least one transfer in Karnataka				0.995*** (0.00641)
At least one transfer in Gujarat				0.806*** (0.00441)
At least one transfer in Andhra Pradesh				1.032*** (0.00610)
At least one transfer in Odisha				1.034*** (0.00523)
At least one transfer in Telangana				0.967*** (0.00531)
At least one transfer in Kerala				0.815*** (0.00408)
At least one transfer in Jharkhand				1.061*** (0.0125)
At least one transfer in Punjab				0.912*** (0.00702)
Observations	6036575	6036396	6036396	6036396
Adjusted R-squared	0.43	0.50	0.54	0.51
Dependent variable mean	0.39	0.39	0.39	0.39
Courtroom fixed effects		✓	✓	✓
Filing month-year fixed effects			✓	✓

Notes: The independent variables are indicators for whether cases experienced one or more transfers. Standard errors clustered by courtroom. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$. See text for details.